

INTERNATIONAL MANAGERS / US WORKPLACES

Cross-Cultural Leadership English

Clear language for decisive, respectful leadership.

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Eight lessons. Eleven extended conversations.

INSIDE THE BOOK

192 vocabulary entries / 128 reusable phrases
220 extended-dialogue turns / 11 transfer exchanges
Word banks and explained answer keys

Upper-intermediate to advanced (B2-C1). For international managers, cross-border teams, and workplace English learners.

2026 edition

Eight scenarios. Eight skills.

Build the language of clear decisions, constructive disagreement, and trusted working relationships.

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Direct is not the same as hostile.

A colleague can strongly challenge an idea without disliking its author. A friendly manner can also hide a real objection. Words, follow-up behavior, power, and context matter more than nationality. Ask what a statement means before deciding what the speaker intended.

THE PRACTICAL DISTINCTION

Accept a testable challenge. Clarify an ambiguous message. Set a boundary around personal contempt, threats, or repeated interruption. You do not need to infer a hidden motive to name an observable problem.

Strong task disagreement

"I do not buy that estimate. The trial took twice as long."

Ask: "Which part of the trial is comparable, and what estimate does it support?"

Ambiguous assent

"Fine. Let us move on."

Check: "Does that approve the date, or only the approach? What remains conditional?"

Personal disrespect

"You clearly do not understand your job."

Set a limit: "Please address the evidence, not my competence. Which claim are you disputing?"

Threat or intimidation

"You will regret raising this."

Pause the exchange if needed. Use the appropriate workplace reporting or support route. An English exercise is not a substitute for a safety or conduct process.

Check the local norm explicitly

First names do not remove decision authority. An invitation to debate is not a transfer of approval rights. Silence does not establish consent. "I will try" does not specify a deliverable. A private conversation does not remove the need for an accurate shared decision record.

Communication practice, not a national personality guide: individuals and organizations vary. Psychological-safety research concerns whether teams can take interpersonal risks, such as asking questions; it does not require the absence of disagreement [3]. Language activities draw on interaction and mediation themes in the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR) [1].

When "fine" is not a green light

A Read the situation

Clarify scope, distinguish acknowledgment from approval, and confirm conditions.

Aiko recorded agreement to a Monday product launch after hearing that the plan was "fine." Jordan then sent a staffing concern. The branch has six trained people; the launch plan needs eight. Two more people may finish training on Friday, but completion is not yet confirmed. Aiko can authorize the branch launch after the staffing check.

PEOPLE / Aiko: International branch manager | Jordan: US-based operations lead

ACKNOWLEDGMENT IS NOT AUTHORIZATION

A nod, "fine," or "I see" can acknowledge a message without approving the proposed action. This ambiguity is not unique to any nationality. A manager who hears agreement can check it without embarrassing the speaker: identify the precise decision, name any condition, and read back the record. Do not ask whether the colleague is "really committed" when the unresolved issue is staffing.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. Which point is confirmed before the conversation?

- | | |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| A Eight people are trained. | B Six people are trained. |
| C Monday has been approved. | D Friday training is complete. |

2. Who can authorize the branch launch after the check?

- | | |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------|
| A Jordan alone | B Either trainee |
| C Aiko | D Nobody named in the case |

3. What needs clarification?

- | | |
|--|--|
| A Whether "fine" approved the date or only the general plan | B Whether scheduling Friday training confirms both people are ready |
| C Whether acknowledging the minutes replaces the staffing check | D Whether Jordan can authorize the launch by confirming the wording |

Answers and explanations: [page 85](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

acknowledgment

A signal that a message has been received or understood.

IN USE acknowledge receipt

endorsement

An expression of support for a proposal or position.

IN USE endorse a proposal

authorization

Permission from someone entitled to approve an action.

IN USE obtain authorization

reservation

A concern that limits or qualifies support.

IN USE express a reservation

provisional

Not final; subject to a stated check or decision.

IN USE provisional launch date

dependency

Something that must happen for another action to proceed.

IN USE resolve a dependency

read-back

A spoken restatement used to check the shared record.

IN USE give a read-back

sign-off

A formal or agreed approval step.

IN USE get final sign-off

scope

The limits of what a statement or agreement covers.

IN USE clarify the scope

conditional agreement

Support that applies only if a requirement is met.

IN USE record conditional agreement

go/no-go decision

A decision to proceed or stop at a defined checkpoint.

IN USE make a go/no-go decision

green light

Informal permission to proceed, not merely positive feedback.

IN USE give the green light

Precision check

Acknowledgment confirms that a message was received or understood. Endorsement expresses support. Authorization permits action. Ask which of these the speaker is giving; do not record one as another.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

clarification

Additional detail that resolves an unclear meaning.

IN USE seek clarification

alignment

A shared understanding or compatible direction; not necessarily formal approval.

IN USE check alignment on the date

pending

Waiting for an event, result, or decision.

IN USE approval pending review

prerequisite

A requirement that must be met before another action.

IN USE satisfy a prerequisite

assumption

Something treated as true before it has been established.

IN USE test an assumption

explicit

Stated directly rather than left for the listener to infer.

IN USE obtain explicit approval

implicit

Suggested or understood without being stated directly.

IN USE avoid relying on implicit consent

qualification

A condition or limitation attached to a statement.

IN USE add a qualification

tentative

Not firmly settled and still open to change.

IN USE set a tentative date

supersede

Replace an earlier record, instruction, or decision.

IN USE supersede the earlier minutes

discrepancy

A difference between accounts or records that should match.

IN USE resolve a discrepancy

in principle

At the level of the general idea, with details still unresolved.

IN USE agree in principle

Precision check

"We agree in principle" supports the general idea. "We have authorized the launch" permits an action. A tentative date and a pending decision identify what remains unsettled.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

SPECIFY THE REFERENCE

"When you say "fine," are you referring to the date or the overall approach?"

STATE THE CONDITION

"My support is conditional on having eight trained people."

PRESERVE UNCERTAINTY

"That remains provisional until we complete the staffing check."

READ BACK THE AGREEMENT

"Let me read that back so we have the same decision record."

SEPARATE TWO MEANINGS

"I heard support for the approach, not approval of the date."

CHECK A COMMITMENT

"Can I record that as a commitment, or is it still a possibility?"

MAKE AN INDIRECT QUESTION

"Could you confirm whether the additional training is complete?"

CLOSE THE LOOP

"I will send the revised record and ask you to confirm it."

Embedded questions

Use "Could you confirm whether the training is complete?" The clause after "whether" has statement order, not "whether is the training complete."

Meaning of "not yet"

"Not yet approved" leaves approval open. "Not approved" can sound like a refusal unless the context makes the pending status clear.

Precision before politeness

"Are we aligned?" is broad. "Are you approving Monday, provided that eight people are trained?" checks an action and its condition.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

EXPOSE AN ASSUMPTION

"I may be reading more into that than you intended."

CHECK THE REFERENCE

"By 'ready,' do you mean trained, scheduled, or available for the first shift?"

IDENTIFY THE MISSING EVIDENCE

"What evidence would let us change the status from pending to confirmed?"

REPLACE AN INACCURATE RECORD

"This note supersedes the earlier statement that the date was final."

LIMIT GENERAL AGREEMENT

"We agree in principle; the staffing condition is still open."

SEPARATE RESPONSE AND DECISION

"Please acknowledge receipt separately from confirming approval."

QUALIFY A DATE

"Monday is our working date, subject to the Friday staffing check."

CHECK THE WHOLE CONDITION

"Is there any condition missing from that summary?"

Name the reference

Replace a vague "that" with the relevant noun: "Do you support the sequence, the date, or both?"

Keep the qualification attached

"We support Monday, provided that eight people are trained" keeps the condition in the same sentence as the support.

Replace rather than add

"This note supersedes the earlier minutes" identifies which record now applies. "Here is another note" leaves that uncertain.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Choose the question that checks authorization, not receipt.

- A** Did you see the revised plan?
- B** Did the plan reach your inbox?
- C** Have you authorized the Monday launch?
- D** Would you like a shorter copy?

2. Complete: "Could you clarify whether ___?"

- A** is the date final
- B** the date is final
- C** does the date final
- D** the date final is it

3. Choose the record supported by the briefing.

- A** Eight staff confirmed; Monday approved.
- B** No staffing concerns were raised.
- C** Jordan has canceled the product.
- D** Monday is provisional pending a staffing check.

4. Which collocation means to settle an outstanding requirement?

- A** resolve a dependency
- B** receive a deadline
- C** endorse a receipt
- D** authorize a reservation

[Answers and explanations: page 85.](#)

When "fine" is not a green light

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

authorization / unconfirmed / flag / reservation / conditional / certify / read-back /
acknowledgment / still provisional / green light

- 01 **Aiko:** Can we revisit Monday? I wrote it down as agreed, but your email says staffing is still an issue. Have I misunderstood you?
- 02 **Jordan:** You did. I was comfortable with the sequence, but I was not giving the
¹ _____ for Monday. We still have two people waiting to finish training.
- 03 **Aiko:** All right. When you said "fine," did you mean the sequence was workable, while the date still depended on the training?
- 04 **Jordan:** Exactly. My support was ² _____. Six people are trained now; we need eight. I should have stated the condition in the meeting.
- 05 **Aiko:** Right, I moved too quickly there. Have the two remaining people completed the final assessment?
- 06 **Jordan:** Not yet. Friday is the scheduled assessment, not a confirmed completion date. Until the results are in, the extra capacity is ³ _____.
- 07 **Aiko:** Then I will correct the record. We support the launch sequence, but Monday is not authorized. Is there another constraint that I have missed?
- 08 **Jordan:** Only the handover. A trained supervisor must cover the first shift. I can check the roster, but I cannot ⁴ _____ the training results myself.
- 09 **Aiko:** Understood. Please check the supervisor coverage and send me the assessment result by 3 p.m. branch time on Friday. Can you commit to that update, even if a result is missing?
- 10 **Jordan:** Yes. I can commit to an update, not a passing result. If either result is missing, I will
⁵ _____ it rather than leave the field blank.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 10.

- 11 **Aiko:** Then I will mark the assessments pending. We can use confirmed when the results arrive, or blocked if something prevents the launch.
- 12 **Jordan:** That works. Could we also separate ⁶ _____ from approval in the minutes? People sometimes say "understood" just to show they have heard the instruction.
- 13 **Aiko:** Yes. I will ask the decision owner to state approval explicitly. In this case that is me, after I review your staffing check.
- 14 **Jordan:** And if I say I have a ⁷ _____, please keep the decision open long enough for me to explain it. I do not mean that I reject the whole plan.
- 15 **Aiko:** Agreed. One last check: if both assessments pass and the supervisor is available, you support Monday. If either condition fails, we discuss a new date. Correct?
- 16 **Jordan:** Correct. That is an accurate ⁸ _____. It captures the conditions without turning them into guarantees.
- 17 **Aiko:** I will amend the minutes now and label Monday provisional. We will make the go/no-go decision after your Friday update, not before it.
- 18 **Jordan:** Please send me the revised paragraph. I can confirm its accuracy today; that confirmation should not be treated as ⁹ _____ to launch.
- 19 **Aiko:** I will make that distinction explicit. Thank you for raising it before the team acted on the old record.
- 20 **Jordan:** Thanks for checking. Next time I will say, "The sequence works; the date is ¹⁰ _____." That leaves less room for a different interpretation.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 86

1. green light | 2. conditional | 3. unconfirmed | 4. certify | 5. flag | 6. acknowledgment | 7. reservation | 8. read-back | 9. authorization | 10. still provisional

A vendor demonstration, not a purchase

F Say it

Aiko and Jordan now discuss a software demonstration. The team likes the interface. Security review is pending, and the purchasing director alone can approve a contract.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

constitute / positive feedback on the demonstration / subject to / approval authority

Aiko: "The team likes the interface. May I record that as ¹ _____?"

Jordan: "Yes, but the purchase remains ² _____ security review."

Aiko: "Who has ³ _____ for the contract?"

Jordan: "The purchasing director. Our positive feedback does not
⁴ _____ that approval."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 86

1. positive feedback on the demonstration | 2. subject to | 3. approval authority | 4. constitute

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10 with a partner; insert your selected answers without adding facts.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Pause after each clarification question until the partner finishes the printed reply.
3. Read the four-line vendor conversation twice, switching roles. Use the answer key only after both readers have selected their choices.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

A sharp objection at the budget review

A Read the situation

Probe evidence, make a concession without surrendering the decision, and set a conduct boundary.

Mei proposes a six-week pilot with two account managers. Chris says, "This proposal makes no sense." The plan assumes two hours of follow-up per account each week; the last trial used four. The staffing allocation is fixed for this pilot. Mei can revise the account count, but cannot add staff without separate approval.

PEOPLE / Mei: International branch manager | Chris: US-based commercial lead

TEST THE CLAIM; ADDRESS THE DELIVERY

Some colleagues use debate to test a proposal rather than signal personal dislike. That possibility does not excuse contempt. Ask which assumption is challenged and what evidence would change the conclusion. A claim about the plan is different from a judgment about your competence. If the speaker insults people or repeatedly talks over them, name the behavior and set a limit; you do not need to prove hostile intent before doing so.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. Which assumption is contradicted by the previous trial?

A The pilot lasts six weeks.

B Two managers are allocated.

C Follow-up will take two hours.

D Mei chairs the meeting.

2. Which adjustment is within Mei's stated authority?

A Add a third manager immediately.

B Change the number of pilot accounts.

C Guarantee that follow-up will halve.

D Waive all customer-service requirements.

3. Which response separates the issue from the person?

A Ask for the challenged assumption and supporting evidence.

B Ask whether Chris likes Mei.

C Treat the criticism as automatic disloyalty.

D Accept the whole objection without checking it.

Answers and explanations: page 87.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

pushback

Resistance or a challenge to a request or proposal.

IN USE offer constructive pushback

premise

A starting claim on which an argument depends.

IN USE challenge the premise

stress-test

Examine a plan under difficult but plausible conditions.

IN USE stress-test an assumption

counterproposal

A different proposal offered in response.

IN USE put forward a counterproposal

evidence base

The information supporting a conclusion or estimate.

IN USE strengthen the evidence base

concession

A point accepted without necessarily accepting the entire argument.

IN USE make a limited concession

feasibility

Whether something can realistically be done.

IN USE assess feasibility

capacity constraint

A limit on the work available people or systems can handle.

IN USE work within a capacity constraint

non-negotiable

A requirement that cannot be traded away in this discussion.

IN USE state a non-negotiable

personal remark

A comment about a person rather than the issue under review.

IN USE avoid personal remarks

burden of proof

Responsibility for supplying evidence for a claim.

IN USE meet the burden of proof

devil's advocate

Someone testing a position by arguing against it, sometimes without holding that view.

IN USE play devil's advocate

Precision check

A concession accepts a particular point, not necessarily the whole argument. A counterproposal offers a different course of action. Constructive pushback needs neither personal agreement nor personal criticism.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

rebuttal

A response that challenges an argument with reasons or evidence.

IN USE offer an evidence-based rebuttal

rationale

The reasoning behind a choice or proposal.

IN USE explain the rationale

substantiation

Evidence or reasoning that supports a claim.

IN USE request substantiation

extrapolate

Extend a finding beyond the conditions or data directly observed.

IN USE extrapolate from a small trial

directional evidence

Information suggesting a tendency without establishing a precise result.

IN USE treat the result as directional evidence

false dichotomy

Presenting two alternatives as the only choices when others exist.

IN USE challenge a false dichotomy

point of contention

The particular issue on which people disagree.

IN USE isolate the point of contention

constructive dissent

Reasoned disagreement intended to improve a decision.

IN USE invite constructive dissent

ad hominem

Directed at the person instead of addressing the argument.

IN USE avoid ad hominem attacks

red line

An informal term for a limit that must not be crossed.

IN USE state a clear red line

viable alternative

Another course of action that can realistically work.

IN USE offer a viable alternative

common ground

A purpose or position shared by people who disagree.

IN USE establish common ground

Precision check

A rebuttal challenges the reasoning; an ad hominem attack targets the person. Directional evidence can justify further testing without substantiating a full rollout. State exactly how far the evidence supports the claim.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

ASK FOR THE PREMISE

"Which assumption are you challenging?"

CONCEDE ONE POINT

"I accept the capacity concern; I do not accept that the whole pilot is unworkable."

SET A BOUNDARY

"Challenge the proposal, please, not the competence of the people presenting it."

LIMIT CERTAINTY

"That evidence supports a smaller pilot, not a guaranteed failure."

REQUEST EVIDENCE

"What are you basing that estimate on?"

NAME THE DISTINCTION

"Let us separate the objective from the proposed method."

INVITE AN ALTERNATIVE

"What would a workable version look like within the same staffing limit?"

CLOSE FIRMLY

"We will revise the account count and test the workload before expanding."

Concession + contrast

Use "I accept X; however, Y remains unresolved." Acceptance of one point is not agreement with the whole conclusion.

Calibrated certainty

"The trial suggests" is narrower than "The trial proves." Match the strength of the verb to the evidence available.

Boundary + invitation

Combine a limit with a route back to the work: "No personal remarks. Please show us the workload calculation."

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

NARROW THE DISAGREEMENT

"Our point of contention is the time estimate, not the need for the pilot."

TEST A BROAD CLAIM

"What would have to be true for that conclusion to hold?"

REJECT A FALSE CHOICE

"Our choices are not limited to the current plan or canceling the pilot."

LIMIT EXTRAPOLATION

"We should not extrapolate to a full rollout from this sample alone."

CHECK COMPARABILITY

"Which conditions in the earlier trial match the conditions we are proposing?"

NAME A SHARED AIM

"We both want a pilot that produces useful evidence without overloading the team."

INVITE A REBUTTAL

"Which part of that calculation would you dispute?"

RESUME AFTER A BOUNDARY

"Now that we have addressed the remark, let us compare the two options."

Challenge a claim, not a motive

"That estimate needs substantiation" requests evidence. "You are trying to mislead us" assigns a motive that the figures alone do not establish.

Find a third option

"Either we launch at full scale or cancel" excludes a smaller trial. "Could we reduce the scope?" reopens that option.

Different levels of firmness

"The sample may be too small" allows uncertainty about evidence. "Please stop the personal remarks" states a conduct boundary directly.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Choose the response that concedes a fact but preserves a narrower proposal.

- A** You are wrong about everything.
- B** I accept the four-hour figure; a smaller pilot may still fit.
- C** The whole project is canceled.
- D** Your tone proves the numbers are false.

2. Complete: "The previous trial ____ a workload risk; it does not prove failure."

- A** guarantees
- B** eliminates
- C** conceals
- D** indicates

3. Which sentence sets a conduct boundary without rejecting criticism?

- A** Do not question my proposal.
- B** Your concern is unwelcome.
- C** Please keep the comments on the proposal, not the people.
- D** We will stop collecting evidence.

4. Which question asks for a counterproposal within the constraint?

- A** How many accounts can two managers support?
- B** Can we assume two hours now and check the workload after expansion?
- C** Can we add one manager to preserve the planned account count?
- D** Can we count the earlier four-hour figure as a guarantee of failure?

Answers and explanations: page 87.

A sharp objection at the budget review

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

premise / stress-test / concede / impact / evidence gap / non-negotiable / validate / counterproposal / retain / scrutiny

- 01 **Chris:** This proposal makes no sense. Two account managers cannot run a pilot on that scale and keep their normal accounts. We will burn through the team before week two.
- 02 **Mei:** I want to understand the objection. Which ¹ _____ are you challenging: the number of accounts, the follow-up time, or the length of the pilot?
- 03 **Chris:** The follow-up time. Your sheet allows two hours per account each week. The last trial took four, and it had fewer handoffs than this one.
- 04 **Mei:** Then we have a specific ² _____, not just a general concern. Can you show us the trial log and explain what is comparable?
- 05 **Chris:** Yes. Here are the entries. Most of the time went into resolving customer questions, not administration. A new template will not remove those conversations.
- 06 **Mei:** I ³ _____ that point. We should not assume the template halves the workload. I am not yet persuaded that we must abandon the pilot.
- 07 **Chris:** If you want my honest view, the team that wrote this has not understood the customers. That is why the estimate is so far off.
- 08 **Mei:** Please keep this on the workload, not the team's competence. I welcome ⁴ _____, but personal judgments will not help us verify the estimate.
- 09 **Chris:** Fair point. That was too personal. My concern is the estimate. I am trying to prevent an overloaded team, not undermine you.
- 10 **Mei:** I hear you. But the ⁵ _____ on the team still matters. Please correct that remark, and then let us work through your alternative.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 19.

- 11 **Chris:** Within two managers, I would cut the account count in half. We could then measure actual follow-up time before asking for a larger allocation.
- 12 **Mei:** That is a useful ⁶ _____. Keeping the staffing fixed matters, because additional headcount would need a different approval.
- 13 **Chris:** Wait, would half the accounts tell us enough? We still need a useful pilot, not just a manageable one.
- 14 **Mei:** We need to test that. A smaller sample may give directional evidence, but it will not ⁷ _____ a full rollout. We will state that limitation in the review.
- 15 **Chris:** Then I can support a smaller pilot if we agree on what it can and cannot establish. I would also want a workload check after the first week.
- 16 **Mei:** Agreed. The staffing limit is ⁸ _____ for this decision, but the account count and review points are open to adjustment.
- 17 **Chris:** I will work with operations on the revised count. I also owe the team a correction for the remark about their understanding of customers.
- 18 **Mei:** Please make that correction in the same group. We can ⁹ _____ the disagreement about the design without leaving the personal remark unaddressed.
- 19 **Chris:** I will. The estimate needs work; I had no basis for questioning the team. I will say that before we circulate the revision.
- 20 **Mei:** Good. Our decision is to ¹⁰ _____ the workload assumption with a smaller pilot, not to treat either of today's estimates as a guarantee.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 88

1. premise | 2. evidence gap | 3. concede | 4. scrutiny | 5. impact | 6. counterproposal | 7. validate | 8. non-negotiable | 9. retain | 10. stress-test

Challenge a sales forecast

F Say it

A forecast assumes ten renewals. Only seven customers have confirmed. You can revise the forecast, but you cannot promise the other three renewals.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

can substantiate / confirmations / assumption / possible

Chris: "The forecast is optimistic. Which ¹ _____ support ten renewals?"

Mei: "I ² _____ seven confirmed renewals, not ten."

Chris: "Then label the other three as ³ _____, not committed."

Mei: "Agreed. We will challenge the ⁴ _____, not the forecaster's character."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 88

1. confirmations | 2. can substantiate | 3. possible | 4. assumption

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-10 once with a neutral tone and once with firm emphasis on "workload" and "competence." Keep the words unchanged.
2. Switch roles for turns 11-20. Pause at each concession or boundary; the listener repeats that exact phrase before continuing.
3. Complete the forecast conversation, then read it without substituting "confirmed" for "possible."

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Delegating without disappearing

A Read the situation

03

Define decision rights, invite recommendations, and delegate within explicit limits.

Sofia has been approving every small change to an onboarding process. Alex wants the team to act faster but does not know where its authority ends. For this fictional project, Sofia can delegate changes to internal task order. Customer promises and additional spending still require her approval. A process trial will run for two weeks.

PEOPLE / Sofia: International customer-service manager | Alex: US-based team lead

CONSULTATION IS NOT A VOTE

A manager can invite disagreement and still own the final decision. Conversely, an invitation to "take ownership" does not tell a team which decisions it can make. The missing information is authority, not confidence. Specify what is delegated, what needs consultation, and what remains reserved. Do not equate an employee's request for clarity with reluctance to lead, or a confident suggestion with a claim to unlimited authority.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. Which decision can Sofia delegate in this case?

- A** Any new customer promise
- C** Internal task order

- B** Additional spending
- D** All employment decisions

2. What remains reserved to Sofia?

- A** Naming a working file
- C** Every routine conversation

- B** Customer promises and extra spending
- D** The team's personal preferences

3. How long will the process trial run?

- A** Two days
- C** An unspecified period

- B** Two months
- D** Two weeks

Answers and explanations: [page 89](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

decision rights

Who may recommend, approve, or decide a particular matter.

IN USE clarify decision rights

delegation

Giving another person defined responsibility or authority.

IN USE delegate a decision

discretion

Freedom to choose within stated limits.

IN USE exercise discretion

guardrail

A limit intended to keep a decision within an acceptable range.

IN USE set clear guardrails

escalation threshold

The point at which an issue must go to another authority.

IN USE agree an escalation threshold

decision owner

The person accountable for making a particular decision.

IN USE name the decision owner

consultation

Seeking input before an action or decision.

IN USE hold a consultation

consensus

Broad agreement, which must not be inferred from silence alone.

IN USE build consensus

accountability

Responsibility for explaining actions and following through.

IN USE retain accountability

remit

The area of work or authority assigned to a role.

IN USE stay within your remit

exception

A case that falls outside the normal rule or arrangement.

IN USE approve an exception

RACI

A role map: Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed. Organizations may apply it differently.

IN USE use a RACI matrix

Precision check

Consultation asks for input; consensus requires shared agreement. Delegation grants specified authority, not unlimited discretion. State the remit and escalation threshold before asking someone to take ownership.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

mandate

An assigned purpose and authority to carry out work.

IN USE define the team's mandate

autonomy

Freedom to organize or decide work within agreed limits.

IN USE grant operational autonomy

approval boundary

The point beyond which a decision needs another person's permission.

IN USE respect the approval boundary

retained authority

Decision power that is not passed to the person doing the work.

IN USE specify retained authority

decision gate

A checkpoint at which a named owner decides whether work may proceed.

IN USE pass a decision gate

span of control

The number of people or teams directly supervised by one manager.

IN USE review a manager's span of control

separation of duties

Dividing important tasks among roles to reduce conflicts or unchecked control.

IN USE maintain separation of duties

oversight

Monitoring and review by someone responsible for the work.

IN USE retain management oversight

accountable owner

The person answerable for a specified result or decision.

IN USE name an accountable owner

approval matrix

A table showing who can approve which decisions and limits.

IN USE check the approval matrix

revocable

Able to be withdrawn by the person or body granting it.

IN USE grant revocable authority

informed stakeholder

Someone who needs updates but does not necessarily decide.

IN USE keep an informed stakeholder updated

Precision check

Autonomy describes room to act; oversight describes how the work is monitored. They can coexist. An informed stakeholder receives updates, a consulted colleague supplies input, and an approver grants permission.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

03

INVITE A RECOMMENDATION

"Bring me your preferred option and the reason for it."

RESERVE A DECISION

"Customer commitments remain my decision."

DEFINE AN ESCALATION

"If the change affects a customer promise, bring it back to me."

PREVENT SILENT CONSENT

"I will ask each owner to confirm the responsibilities assigned to them."

DELEGATE CLEARLY

"You may change the internal sequence without seeking approval each time."

SET A LIMIT

"That discretion does not include additional spending."

DISTINGUISH ROLES

"I need your input; I am not asking you to make the final decision."

SCHEDULE REVIEW

"We will review the trial after two weeks using the agreed criteria."

Permission and obligation

"You may" grants permission. "You must" states a requirement. "You can" may describe either ability or permission; make the context explicit.

Within and beyond

"Within your remit" identifies permitted scope. "Beyond your remit" signals a need for a different owner or approval.

Consult versus approve

"Consult finance" requires input; it does not automatically give finance final approval authority. State the actual arrangement.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

03

DEFINE AUTONOMY

"Within the agreed limits, the task order is yours to decide."

CHECK A BOUNDARY

"Does this change fall within the authority you have delegated to me?"

NAME THE ACCOUNTABLE OWNER

"Let us name one person who is answerable for the trial result."

EXPLAIN THE CHECKPOINT

"The two-week review is a decision gate, not automatic permission to continue."

KEEP OVERSIGHT EXPLICIT

"I am delegating the sequence, not stepping away from oversight."

DISTINGUISH RECOMMENDATION AND ACTION

"You may recommend the tool, but purchasing it still requires approval."

REQUIRE TIMELY ESCALATION

"Raise the issue before making the customer commitment, not afterward."

CONFIRM UNDERSTANDING

"Please state which decisions you can make and which you will bring back to me."

Name the actor

"Sofia approves additional spending" identifies the owner. "Spending must be approved" names a requirement but leaves the owner unclear.

Permission is not a requirement

"You may adjust the order" permits a change; "you must adjust the order" requires it. Keep this distinction when relaying instructions.

Separate advice from authority

"I recommend buying the tool" gives advice. "I authorize the purchase" grants permission only when the speaker holds that authority.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which instruction delegates authority with a clear boundary?

- A** Use your judgment about everything.
- B** Wait for me before changing any file.
- C** Act as if every request is approved.
- D** Reorder internal tasks; seek approval before changing customer promises.

2. Complete: "You ___ notify me if a change affects a customer promise." The requirement is compulsory.

- A** might
- B** must
- C** could
- D** may

3. Which statement describes consultation, not approval?

- A** Finance supplies cost information before Sofia decides.
- B** Finance authorizes the spending.
- C** Finance issues final sign-off.
- D** Finance has vetoed the request.

4. The team disagrees after everyone has contributed. What is still possible?

- A** The invitation to contribute transfers final approval to the team.
- B** Consultation automatically requires unanimity before any choice.
- C** Sofia can decide after considering the input.
- D** Alex may approve extra spending because he coordinates the trial.

Answers and explanations: [page 89](#).

Delegating without disappearing

E Conversations / turns 1-10

03

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

remit / delegated / exception / decision rights / review / escalation threshold / accountability / consulted / responsibilities / discretion

- 01 **Alex:** The team wants more freedom on onboarding, but "take ownership" has not been clear enough. Yesterday we waited for your reply before moving a routine internal check.
- 02 **Sofia:** That is a fair criticism. I have asked for initiative without defining the
1 _____. Let us separate what you can decide from what needs my approval.
- 03 **Alex:** Our recommendation is to move the internal document check earlier. It would not change what we promise customers or require additional spending.
- 04 **Sofia:** You have my permission to decide the internal task order. That is now
2 _____ to you for the two-week trial; you do not need to ask about each change.
- 05 **Alex:** Does that include changing a customer's promised completion date if an internal delay makes the original date difficult?
- 06 **Sofia:** No. Customer promises are outside that 3 _____. Bring those changes to me with the reason and the options before making a new commitment.
- 07 **Alex:** Understood. And if the team wants a paid document-checking tool, we should stop at the spending boundary rather than order it and tell you afterward.
- 08 **Sofia:** Exactly. Additional spending is an 4 _____ that needs approval. The team can research the tool and recommend it, but not purchase it under this delegation.
- 09 **Alex:** I would like input from customer support before choosing the sequence. Do they need to agree, or is their role to identify problems we might miss?
- 10 **Sofia:** For the internal sequence, they are 5 _____. You make the decision after using their input. Do not describe their silence as agreement.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

03

Continue with the word bank on page 28.

- 11 **Alex:** Then I will send them two options and ask for risks by Thursday noon. If they need more time, they can say so rather than approve by default.
- 12 **Sofia:** Good. If a disagreement concerns only internal order, resolve it within your ⁶ _____. If it affects a customer promise, bring it to me.
- 13 **Alex:** And if this creates more rework? I am happy to own the decision, but I will need your help getting another team involved.
- 14 **Sofia:** I retain management ⁷ _____ for the trial. You are responsible for coordinating it, collecting the results, and raising issues promptly. I will help remove obstacles.
- 15 **Alex:** Could we put that on one page? Our old RACI chart still lists you as approving every change. People will follow that unless we replace it.
- 16 **Sofia:** Yes. Use plain role descriptions first. A matrix is useful only if the team understands the ⁸ _____, not just the letters.
- 17 **Alex:** I will record the boundary as: internal sequence, Alex decides; customer promises or spending, Sofia approves. Support provides input before the sequence is chosen.
- 18 **Sofia:** That captures it. Add an ⁹ _____: contact me before a proposed change would alter either a customer promise or the spending limit.
- 19 **Alex:** I will circulate that today and ask each named person to confirm their role. Then we can start the trial on Monday.
- 20 **Sofia:** And we will hold the ¹⁰ _____ at the end of week two. Bring the rework count and the time taken; we will decide whether to keep, adjust, or stop the sequence.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 90

1. decision rights | 2. delegated | 3. remit | 4. exception | 5. consulted | 6. discretion | 7. accountability | 8. responsibilities | 9. escalation threshold | 10. review

A conference booking

F Say it

Sofia permits Alex to choose a room within an approved \$2,000 budget. Changes to the event date require Sofia's approval. No extra spending is authorized.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

my decision / seek your approval / approval boundary / may

Sofia: "You ¹ _____ choose the room within the approved budget."

Alex: "If every suitable room costs more, I will ² _____ before booking."

Sofia: "Changing the event date remains ³ _____."

Alex: "I will record the budget and the ⁴ _____ so the team knows when to contact you."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 90

1. may | 2. seek your approval | 3. my decision | 4. approval boundary

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read the dialogue with one reader as Sofia and one as Alex. After turns 4, 6, and 10, repeat the stated permission or boundary exactly.
2. Switch roles and read turns 15-20 as a decision-record check. Do not add authority that the record does not grant.
3. Read the conference exchange using the selected options. Finish by repeating the budget and the reserved date decision.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Friday estimates or Monday verified figures

04

A Read the situation

Offer bounded alternatives, use conditional commitments, and distinguish a forecast from a promise.

Headquarters needs branch figures for a Friday planning meeting. Omar can send an estimate by 3 p.m. New York time on Friday or verified figures by noon New York time on Monday. The supplier reconciliation will not finish before Monday morning. Priya can choose the reporting option but cannot make reconciliation finish early. Estimates must be labeled as provisional.

PEOPLE / Omar: International branch operations manager | Priya: Headquarters project sponsor

A CLEAR LIMIT CAN PROTECT TRUST

A quick "yes" may reduce tension in the call while creating a commitment the branch cannot meet. A vague "we will try" can also be heard as a promise. Name the deliverable, deadline, and condition separately. Offer a choice that serves the other person's purpose. Do not present willingness as capacity, or describe a required accuracy check as resistance to headquarters.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What can Omar supply on Friday?

A Verified figures

B A labeled estimate

C A completed reconciliation

D A guaranteed final result

2. What cannot Priya change simply by choosing an option?

A The report's intended use

B The meeting audience

C The reconciliation completion constraint

D Whether to accept an estimate

3. Which wording preserves both the Friday deliverable and its time reference?

A Verified figures Friday at 3 p.m. New York time

B A provisional estimate Friday at 3 p.m. headquarters time

C A provisional estimate by local end of day Friday

D A provisional estimate Friday at 3 p.m. New York time

Answers and explanations: page 91.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

deliverable

A specific output someone agrees to provide.

IN USE define the deliverable

turnaround time

Time from a request or input to a completed response.

IN USE agree a turnaround time

trade-off

A choice in which one benefit comes at the cost of another.

IN USE make a trade-off

reconciliation

Checking records against one another and resolving differences.

IN USE complete the reconciliation

verified

Checked against the required evidence or process.

IN USE verified figures

estimate

An approximate figure based on available information.

IN USE provide an estimate

caveat

A stated limitation or qualification.

IN USE include a caveat

scope creep

Uncontrolled growth of the work beyond the agreed scope.

IN USE prevent scope creep

contingency

A provision or alternative for a possible problem.

IN USE plan a contingency

hard deadline

A deadline treated as fixed for the stated purpose.

IN USE meet a hard deadline

best effort

An undertaking to try, not necessarily to deliver a result.

IN USE make a best-effort attempt

overcommit

Promise more than the available capacity can support.

IN USE avoid overcommitting

Precision check

A deliverable is the output promised; a deadline is when it is due. A caveat states a limitation; a contingency states the fallback. An estimate can be useful without being verified, provided its status stays visible.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

critical path

The sequence of dependent work that determines the earliest completion date.

IN USE identify the critical path

buffer

Extra time or capacity kept available for variation or delay.

IN USE build in a time buffer

slippage

Movement of a task or delivery beyond its planned date.

IN USE report schedule slippage

baseline

An agreed starting plan used to compare later performance or changes.

IN USE establish a schedule baseline

rebaseline

Formally replace an agreed plan with a revised reference plan.

IN USE rebaseline the delivery schedule

dependency risk

The possibility that required work elsewhere will delay or block delivery.

IN USE flag a dependency risk

minimum viable scope

The smallest set of work that can still meet the stated purpose.

IN USE agree the minimum viable scope

rolling forecast

A forecast updated regularly as new information becomes available.

IN USE maintain a rolling forecast

range estimate

An estimate expressed as a lower and upper value rather than a single figure.

IN USE provide a range estimate

confidence level

Here, the stated strength of confidence in an estimate, with its basis explained.

IN USE state the confidence level

resource allocation

The assignment of people, time, or other capacity to work.

IN USE confirm resource allocation

acceptance criteria

The conditions an output must meet to be accepted as complete.

IN USE agree acceptance criteria

Precision check

A baseline records the agreed plan. Rebaselining changes that reference explicitly; it should not hide slippage. Here, "confidence level" is ordinary workplace language, not a calculated statistical confidence interval.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

IDENTIFY THE PURPOSE

"What decision does the Friday meeting need to make?"

MAKE A CONDITIONAL OFFER

"We can meet Friday if the deliverable is an explicitly provisional estimate."

PROTECT THE CAVEAT

"Please keep the provisional label when the figures are forwarded."

SEPARATE EFFORT FROM OUTCOME

"I can commit to the update; I cannot guarantee a result we do not control."

OFFER ALTERNATIVES

"We can provide an estimate on Friday or verified figures on Monday."

STATE A FIRM LIMIT

"I cannot commit to verified figures before the reconciliation is complete."

CHECK THE DEADLINE

"Does 'Friday' mean 3 p.m. New York time or your local end of day?"

CONFIRM THE CHOICE

"Then our agreement is Friday estimates, followed by Monday verification."

If + present tense

Use "If the scope stays the same, we can send the estimate on Friday." Do not use "if the scope will stay" for this ordinary future condition.

Provided that

"Provided that" makes a requirement explicit. It does not mean the requirement has already been met.

Cannot versus will not

"Cannot verify before Monday" describes a constraint. "Will not verify" can imply a refusal; select the meaning you intend.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

ASK WHAT IS ESSENTIAL

"Which parts of the report are essential for Friday's decision?"

PROTECT CAPACITY

"To include the other branches, we would need to move the date or reassign people."

AGREE WHAT COMPLETE MEANS

"For this version, does "complete" mean ready for discussion or verified for release?"

PRESERVE THE ORIGINAL PLAN

"Let us record the revised deadline alongside the original baseline."

IDENTIFY THE DEPENDENCY

"The supplier check is on the critical path; extra formatting time will not shorten it."

MAKE UNCERTAINTY VISIBLE

"I can give a range and explain its basis, but a single figure would imply false precision."

REPORT SLIPPAGE EARLY

"The check is at risk of slipping; I will update you before the agreed deadline."

CONFIRM A FALLBACK

"If verification is delayed, the fallback is a status update, not an unchecked final report."

By and until

"Send the report by Friday" sets the latest delivery time. "Keep the estimate provisional until Monday" describes a status continuing up to a point.

Subject to + noun

Use "subject to verification" or "subject to the supplier completing the check," not "subject to verify."

Meet versus deliver

You meet a deadline and deliver a report. "We can meet Friday" needs a clear deadline context; "we can deliver Friday's estimate" names the output.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Choose the commitment supported by the facts.

- A** We guarantee final figures Friday.
- B** We can finish reconciliation tonight.
- C** We can send a labeled estimate Friday at 3 p.m. New York time.
- D** No report of any kind is possible.

2. Complete the ordinary future condition: "If you ___ the estimate option, we can meet Friday."

- A** choose
- B** will choose
- C** would have chosen
- D** choosing

3. Which caveat preserves the status of the Friday figures?

- A** Final and verified
- B** Provisional; reconciliation pending
- C** Approved for every purpose
- D** Guaranteed not to change

4. Which reply clarifies purpose before negotiating the deliverable?

- A** Why do you always rush us?
- B** We will say yes and work it out later.
- C** Accuracy does not matter.
- D** Is Friday's decision about planning capacity or final reporting?

Answers and explanations: [page 91](#).

Friday estimates or Monday verified figures

E Conversations / turns 1-10

04

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

reconciliation / scope creep / provisional / provided that / commit / deliverable / contingency / trade-off / caveat / guarantee

- 01 **Priya:** The planning group needs your branch figures on Friday. Can you send the final report before the meeting? We cannot move the meeting to Monday.
- 02 **Omar:** I can help with Friday, but I need to be clear about the ¹ _____. We can send an estimate then; Monday is our target for verified figures.
- 03 **Priya:** The deck needs one number. What is stopping you from checking it before Friday?
- 04 **Omar:** The supplier ² _____ will not finish before Monday morning. That is a missing check, not a choice to delay the report.
- 05 **Priya:** The group will use the number to compare staffing options. It is not making a final financial filing. Would an estimate be adequate for that discussion?
- 06 **Omar:** Yes, with a clear ³ _____. I can provide the estimate, its basis, and the items not yet reconciled. I cannot describe it as verified.
- 07 **Priya:** Could you remove that warning from the main slide and put it in the notes? The slide is already crowded.
- 08 **Omar:** I need the ⁴ _____ label to stay beside the figure. Otherwise readers may treat the estimate as final when the slide is forwarded without its notes.
- 09 **Priya:** Understood. Keep a short label on the slide and the detail in the notes. What is the earliest time you can send it?
- 10 **Omar:** Friday at 3 p.m. New York time, ⁵ _____ the scope remains this branch and the current reporting period. Adding other branches would change the schedule.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

04

Continue with the word bank on page 37.

- 11 **Priya:** That time works. I was about to add two other branches, but we can leave them out of this version. I will state that in the request.
- 12 **Omar:** Thank you. That avoids ⁶ _____ after we have agreed the deadline. Please send the confirmed scope so I can brief the team accurately.
- 13 **Priya:** For Monday, can I tell the group that the verified number will definitely match Friday's estimate? A change could prompt more questions.
- 14 **Omar:** No. Verification may change it. I can ⁷ _____ to explaining any difference; I cannot guarantee that the number itself will remain unchanged.
- 15 **Priya:** Then we need to explain that before the group makes a decision. I will frame Friday's figure as a planning input, not a certified result.
- 16 **Omar:** That is the right ⁸ _____: speed for the planning meeting, followed by a checked result. We should not claim to have both on Friday.
- 17 **Priya:** What will you do if the supplier check is unexpectedly still incomplete on Monday morning? I would rather hear about a delay early.
- 18 **Omar:** Our ⁹ _____ will be an explicit status update before noon, identifying what remains unresolved and when we can reassess. I will not relabel unchecked data as verified.
- 19 **Priya:** Agreed. I will record the Friday estimate and Monday verified-report target, with that fallback if the supplier check is delayed.
- 20 **Omar:** Please also record that the Friday estimate is not a ¹⁰ _____ of Monday's outcome. With that wording, I can confirm the commitment and brief the team.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 92

1. deliverable | 2. reconciliation | 3. caveat | 4. provisional | 5. provided that | 6. scope creep | 7. commit | 8. trade-off | 9. contingency | 10. guarantee

A presentation with an unfinished review

F Say it

04

A client presentation is requested Tuesday. A ten-slide internal draft can be ready then. Compliance review is scheduled to finish Wednesday, but clearance has not been granted. Only an explicitly cleared version may be sent externally.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

review pending / clears / until / internal

Priya: "Can you deliver ten slides Tuesday?" Omar: "Yes, as an ¹ _____ draft."

Priya: "Can the client receive it then?" Omar: "Not ² _____ compliance grants clearance."

Priya: "Then I will call Tuesday's file ³ _____."

Omar: "If compliance ⁴ _____ the version Wednesday, we can prepare it for release."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 92

1. internal | 2. until | 3. review pending | 4. clears

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read the full dialogue, pausing after each offer so the listener can repeat its deadline and condition.
2. Switch roles and reread turns 7-14. Keep the distinction between a provisional figure and a guaranteed result.
3. Read the presentation exchange with the selected words. Finish by repeating which file may be sent externally.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

The remote question nobody heard

A Read the situation

Manage turn-taking, interrupt constructively, paraphrase accurately, and close a hybrid meeting.

05

Three participants have been speaking over one another. Arun posted a concern in the meeting chat, but nobody responded. The team has fifteen minutes left. The new queue can go live only after routing is checked; Arun has not completed that check. Leila owns the go-live decision, and Ben has been preparing the customer-service schedule.

PEOPLE / Leila: International manager and meeting chair | Ben: US-based service lead | Arun: Remote systems lead

PROTECT ACCESS, NOT JUST AIRTIME

Someone may be quiet because of audio delay, language-processing time, a missed invitation, or uncertainty about the decision. Do not diagnose the reason from silence. Give the remote participant a named turn, stop overlapping speech, and summarize the contribution before moving on. First-name address or an informal manner does not establish that hierarchy has disappeared. The chair still needs to state who decides and whose input is missing.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. Whose input has been missed?

A Leila's decision

C A customer's signed approval

B Arun's routing concern

D An unnamed supplier's invoice

2. What blocks a final go-live decision?

A A completed routing check

C An unfinished routing check

B A full transcript

D A new office location

3. Who owns the go-live decision?

A Leila

C Arun alone

B Ben

D Whoever speaks last

Answers and explanations: [page 93](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

turn-taking

The way speakers enter, hold, and give up a speaking turn.

IN USE manage turn-taking

the floor

The opportunity to speak to the group.

IN USE give someone the floor

crosstalk

Overlapping speech that makes contributions hard to follow.

IN USE reduce crosstalk

timebox

A fixed amount of time allocated to a discussion or task.

IN USE timebox the discussion

round-robin

A sequence in which each participant is invited to contribute.

IN USE use a round-robin

paraphrase

Restate someone's meaning in different words.

IN USE paraphrase a concern

parking lot

An informal list of issues deferred for later attention.

IN USE put an item in the parking lot

dissent

A stated view that differs from the proposal or majority view.

IN USE record dissent

quorum

The minimum attendance required under a group's rules for valid business.

IN USE confirm a quorum

action item

A specific task recorded for follow-up.

IN USE assign an action item

decision log

A record of decisions, owners, and relevant reasons or conditions.

IN USE update the decision log

asynchronous input

A contribution made outside a simultaneous meeting.

IN USE collect asynchronous input

Precision check

Giving someone the floor transfers the speaking turn, not decision authority. An action item assigns work; a decision log records what has been decided or remains pending. Neither silence nor attendance establishes approval.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

facilitation

Helping a group follow a workable process and make progress.

IN USE provide neutral facilitation

speaking queue

The order in which waiting participants will be invited to speak.

IN USE manage the speaking queue

airtime

The amount of meeting time a person uses to speak.

IN USE share airtime fairly

agenda item

A specific topic scheduled for discussion.

IN USE close an agenda item

unresolved question

A question that has not yet received an adequate answer.

IN USE return to an unresolved question

synthesis

A summary that connects important points from several contributions.

IN USE offer a concise synthesis

cross-check

Compare information with another source or person to check accuracy.

IN USE cross-check the meeting summary

recap

A short restatement of the main points just covered.

IN USE give a brief recap

side conversation

A separate exchange that can distract from the main discussion.

IN USE pause a side conversation

deferred item

An issue deliberately moved to a later time.

IN USE assign an owner to a deferred item

meeting owner

The person responsible for arranging and following through on a meeting.

IN USE confirm the meeting owner

pre-read

Material circulated for participants to read before a meeting.

IN USE circulate the pre-read

Precision check

A recap restates the main points; a synthesis connects contributions. A deferred item needs a return point and an owner. Giving access to a discussion does not require treating every contribution as approval.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

STOP OVERLAP

"One voice at a time, please; the remote line cannot distinguish us."

ENTER THE DISCUSSION

"May I come in on the routing point before we move on?"

CHECK A PARAPHRASE

"Have I represented your concern accurately?"

RECORD DISSENT

"I will record the concern without describing it as agreement."

PROTECT A TURN

"Arun has not finished. I will come to you next, Ben."

INVITE A SPECIFIC VIEW

"Arun, what remains unverified in the routing check?"

LIMIT A DIGRESSION

"Let us park the training format and finish the go-live conditions."

CLOSE WITH OWNERSHIP

"The next action belongs to Arun; the go-live decision remains with me."

A useful interruption

State the reason briefly: "Before we move on, Arun's question is still open." This protects an unresolved issue rather than merely taking airtime.

Paraphrase versus infer

"You said the check is incomplete" reports a contribution. "You do not support the project" adds a position the speaker may not hold.

An invitation that can be answered

"Any thoughts?" is broad. "What remains unverified?" gives the invited speaker a precise task.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

MANAGE THE QUEUE

"I have Ben, then Arun, then Leila in the speaking queue."

INCLUDE A MISSED VOICE

"We have not heard from the remote team yet; what would you add on routing?"

CHECK ACCESS TO INFORMATION

"Can everyone see the same version of the pre-read?"

PRESERVE AN OBJECTION

"The summary will show that the scheduling proposal still has an unresolved objection."

PAUSE A SIDE EXCHANGE

"Please pause the side conversation so everyone can hear the answer."

CONNECT TWO CONTRIBUTIONS

"Ben has confirmed the staffing; Arun has identified a separate routing condition."

KEEP A DEFERRED ITEM ALIVE

"We will defer the slide layout, with Ben bringing it back on Thursday."

CLOSE AN ITEM ACCURATELY

"We have assigned the checks, but we have not approved go-live."

Invite without diagnosing

"We have not heard your view on routing" invites a contribution. "You are quiet because you disagree" assumes both a reason and a position.

Protect the next turn

"Please finish, Arun; Ben is next" preserves the current speaker and gives the waiting speaker a clear place.

Close the right thing

"We have finished discussing the checks" closes a discussion. "We have approved go-live" records a decision. One does not automatically imply the other.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Choose the intervention that protects the interrupted speaker.

- A** Arun, send an email instead; we are moving on.
- B** Ben, please finish Arun's explanation.
- C** Arun has not finished; Ben will speak next.
- D** Everyone speak more loudly.

2. Which paraphrase does not add an unsupported conclusion?

- A** Arun wants to cancel the project.
- B** Arun said the routing check is incomplete.
- C** Arun has approved the routing.
- D** Arun refuses to work with Ben.

3. Which action belongs in a decision log?

- A** A guess about why someone was quiet
- B** A comment about someone's accent
- C** A record that all silence meant agreement
- D** Go-live pending; Arun checks routing; Leila decides afterward.

4. Which issue must not be parked before this go-live decision?

- A** The unfinished routing check
- B** An optional training-slide layout revision
- C** A proposed pre-read template for future meetings
- D** A retrospective on the meeting format after the trial

Answers and explanations: [page 93](#).

The remote question nobody heard

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

05

WORD + PHRASE BANK

paraphrase / action items / crosstalk / the floor / decision / dissent / timebox / parking lot / decision log / asynchronous input

- 01 **Ben:** If we start Monday, the schedule is ready. I think we have covered the main points, so can we confirm the switch and send the roster?
- 02 **Leila:** Before we confirm anything, we need to stop the ¹ _____. Three people were speaking, and I could not hear the remote contribution.
- 03 **Arun:** Thank you. I put a question in the chat about routing, but the discussion moved to staffing. I am not saying the schedule is wrong; the technical check is still open.
- 04 **Ben:** I saw a message appear, but I did not read it fully. Arun, you have ² _____. What is the unresolved part?
- 05 **Arun:** We have checked new tickets, but not tickets transferred from the old queue. If those transfers are misrouted, the schedule will not prevent delays.
- 06 **Leila:** Let me ³ _____ that: new tickets have passed the check; transferred tickets have not. So we cannot treat the complete routing check as finished. Is that accurate?
- 07 **Arun:** Yes. I need a test set of transferred tickets and someone from service to confirm that they reach the intended team.
- 08 **Ben:** I can supply that test set. But could we first discuss the training slides? There are several changes I would like to make to the layout.
- 09 **Leila:** Let us put the slide layout in the ⁴ _____. We have fifteen minutes for the go-live conditions, and the routing check is a prerequisite.
- 10 **Arun:** That helps. I need ten representative transferred tickets, not another overview of the training. Ben, can your team provide those by 11 a.m. tomorrow?

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 46.

05

- 11 **Ben:** Yes, by eleven tomorrow. And I should correct my opening: the roster is ready, but I am not the person who approves the switch.
- 12 **Leila:** Correct. The go-live ⁵ _____ is mine. Preparing the schedule is an action, not an approval. I will make that distinction in the record.
- 13 **Arun:** May I add one more condition? I need a service colleague in the test, otherwise we will know the technical destination but not whether the operational routing is useful.
- 14 **Leila:** Yes. I will give you a short ⁶ _____ to finish the conditions, then we will confirm the owner of each task. Ben, please hold your reply until Arun finishes.
- 15 **Arun:** That is the full list: representative transfers and a service colleague. If those are available tomorrow, I can report the test result that afternoon.
- 16 **Ben:** I will name the service colleague and supply the ten tickets. Please record both as my ⁷ _____, with the 11 a.m. deadline.
- 17 **Leila:** Recorded. Arun reports the test result tomorrow afternoon; I decide afterward. Until then, the proposed switch remains pending, not approved.
- 18 **Arun:** Please also record my ⁸ _____ on approving Monday today. I support testing the switch; I do not support releasing it before the check.
- 19 **Ben:** That distinction is clear. I will hold the announcement. If anyone misses the remaining discussion, I will collect their input in the shared note rather than infer agreement.
- 20 **Leila:** Good. The ⁹ _____ will show the pending decision and named owners. We will accept ¹⁰ _____ until tomorrow's check so absent colleagues can identify relevant risks.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 94

1. crosstalk | 2. the floor | 3. paraphrase | 4. parking lot | 5. decision | 6. timebox | 7. action items | 8. dissent | 9. decision log | 10. asynchronous input

A quiet participant on a video call

F Say it

Nora has not spoken. The chair sees her raised-hand signal. The team must check a missing contract attachment before approving a handover.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

pending / paraphrase / the floor / decision log

Chair: "Nora has raised her hand. Let us give her ¹ _____."

Nora: "The attachment is missing; approval is still ² _____."

Chair: "I will ³ _____ your point: we need the attachment before approval."

Nora: "Correct. Please record that in the ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 94

1. the floor | 2. pending | 3. paraphrase | 4. decision log

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Use three readers for the extended dialogue. With two readers, one takes Ben and Arun; alone, read all roles aloud.
2. Read turns 5-7 twice. On the second reading, pause before "Is that accurate?" and wait for the printed confirmation.
3. Read the video-call exchange, then repeat the four completed lines without changing "pending" to "approved."

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Two late reports and one missing handoff

A Read the situation

Describe behavior, explain operational impact, ask about causes, and agree a measurable next step.

06

The weekly report is due at noon on Thursday. In each of the last two weeks it arrived on Friday morning. Planning had to defer a staffing update. Elena does not know why the reports were late. Diego depends on a source file from another team. This is a coaching discussion, not a fictional disciplinary procedure.

PEOPLE / Elena: International department manager | Diego: US-based analyst

SPECIFIC IS CLEARER THAN SEVERE

Feedback can be direct without making a claim about character. Name the two reports and their effect; then ask what happened. "You lack commitment" guesses at motivation. "The last two reports arrived after our agreed deadline" names an observable pattern. The Center for Creative Leadership's Situation-Behavior-Impact approach informs this distinction [2]. Once a cause is explained, a manager can offer support without quietly removing the deadline.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. Which statement describes an observation?

A Diego does not care.

B Diego dislikes the team.

C The last two reports arrived Friday morning.

D Diego always ignores deadlines.

2. What operational effect is known?

A Planning deferred its staffing update.

B A customer ended a contract.

C The branch lost a stated amount of money.

D Diego was formally disciplined.

3. What should Elena avoid assuming before asking?

A The deadline was Thursday noon.

B The cause of the delay.

C There were two late reports.

D Planning used the report.

Answers and explanations: [page 95](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

observable behavior

An action that can be described without guessing at motive.

IN USE describe observable behavior

impact

The effect of an action on people or work.

IN USE explain the impact

attribution

An explanation assigned to someone's behavior or an event.

IN USE check an attribution

pattern

A repeated feature across more than one event.

IN USE identify a pattern

bottleneck

A point that limits the flow or speed of work.

IN USE remove a bottleneck

upstream input

Information or work required from an earlier stage or another team.

IN USE obtain upstream input

lead time

The interval needed before an output or action can be ready.

IN USE allow sufficient lead time

corrective action

An agreed step to address a problem or prevent its recurrence.

IN USE agree corrective action

check-in

A brief conversation to review status or provide support.

IN USE schedule a check-in

follow-through

Carrying out what was agreed, not just agreeing to it.

IN USE demonstrate follow-through

performance expectation

A clear description of the work standard required.

IN USE clarify a performance expectation

SBI

Situation-Behavior-Impact: CCL's sequence for specific feedback.

IN USE use an SBI structure [2]

Precision check

An impact is an effect you can describe; an attribution is an explanation you assign. Check the explanation before treating it as a fact. A check-in reviews progress; follow-through means carrying out the agreed action.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

coaching

Support that helps someone improve specific work or skills.

IN USE hold a coaching conversation

performance gap

The difference between an agreed standard and observed performance.

IN USE identify a performance gap

root cause

An underlying cause whose removal can help prevent the problem recurring.

IN USE investigate the root cause

contributing factor

Something that helps produce an outcome without necessarily being its only cause.

IN USE identify contributing factors

early-warning signal

Information showing that a problem may occur before the outcome is final.

IN USE act on an early-warning signal

recurrence

The return of a problem after an earlier occurrence.

IN USE prevent recurrence

measurable standard

A work requirement whose achievement can be checked against stated evidence.

IN USE set a measurable standard

timeliness

Delivery within the time required for the work to be useful.

IN USE improve report timeliness

rework

Work that must be done again to correct or accommodate a problem.

IN USE reduce avoidable rework

support request

A specific request for help, access, or resources.

IN USE make a concrete support request

action plan

A record of agreed steps, owners, and completion times.

IN USE agree a focused action plan

evidence-based feedback

Feedback tied to observable events or reliable records.

IN USE give evidence-based feedback

Precision check

A contributing factor may be one of several causes. A root-cause claim needs stronger support than a first explanation. Coaching can address a performance gap while retaining the agreed standard and offering concrete support.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

NAME THE OCCASION

"For each of the last two weekly reports, we agreed on Thursday noon."

EXPLAIN IMPACT

"Planning had to defer its staffing update while it waited for the figures."

SEPARATE CAUSE FROM STANDARD

"That explains the delay; we still need an early warning when the input is missing."

SET A TRIGGER

"If the file is missing by Wednesday noon, notify me that day."

DESCRIBE THE BEHAVIOR

"Both reports arrived on Friday morning."

ASK WITHOUT ASSIGNING MOTIVE

"What prevented the Thursday delivery?"

OFFER CONCRETE SUPPORT

"I will speak with the source-team manager about the handoff."

DEFINE FOLLOW-UP

"We will review the next two reports at a short Friday check-in."

06

Past evidence, present expectation

Use past tense for the two arrivals. Use present or future wording for the agreed standard and next steps.

Avoid always and never

Two observed events support "the last two reports," not "you always miss deadlines." Keep the claim as narrow as the evidence.

Question before conclusion

"What prevented delivery?" seeks a cause. "Why were you careless?" builds an unverified judgment into the question.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

CHECK THE STANDARD

"What deadline did you understand us to have agreed?"

LIMIT A CONCLUSION

"These two reports show a delivery problem; they do not establish your motivation."

DEFINE USEFUL SUPPORT

"Would an earlier handoff, access to the source owner, or a clearer trigger help most?"

RECOGNIZE A CORRECTION

"You flagged the missing file before noon this time; that gave planning time to respond."

SEPARATE TWO PROBLEMS

"We need to address both the late source file and the missing early warning."

EXPLORE CONTRIBUTING FACTORS

"Apart from the source file, which steps affected the delivery time?"

MAKE IMPROVEMENT MEASURABLE

"For the next two reports, we will check the delivery time and whether a warning was sent."

AGREE A NEXT STEP

"Please confirm the action you own and when you will report its status."

06

State the time window

"The last two reports were late" identifies the evidence. "Your reports are late" can sound like a broader claim about the person's normal performance.

Bound the support question

"Would an earlier handoff or access to the source owner help?" offers practical options. Follow the answer with a named action and owner.

Recognize the observable improvement

"You warned planning before noon" names a useful action. "Your attitude is better" substitutes a personal judgment for that evidence.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which opening is specific and evidence-based?

- A** Your dependence on the source team caused both delays.
- B** Your Thursday deadlines no longer seem important to you.
- C** The report process fails every week.
- D** The last two reports arrived Friday, after Thursday's noon deadline.

2. Which question does not assume fault or motive?

- A** Why did you deliberately delay it?
- B** What prevented the Thursday delivery?
- C** Why do you dislike planning?
- D** How long have you ignored the team?

3. Choose the early-warning trigger.

- A** Let me know if anything ever seems wrong.
- B** Try harder next time.
- C** If the source file is missing Wednesday noon, notify me that day.
- D** Wait until the next report is late.

4. Which statement preserves the expectation while offering support?

- A** I will address the handoff; you still need to flag missing input early.
- B** No deadline applies once another team is involved.
- C** Keep the missing file secret until Friday.
- D** Promise the report even when the data do not exist.

Answers and explanations: [page 95](#).

Two late reports and one missing handoff

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

06

WORD + PHRASE BANK

corrective / observable behavior / impact / performance expectation / follow-through / check-in / upstream input / lead time / flagged / bottleneck

- 01 **Elena:** I want to discuss the last two weekly reports. We agreed on Thursday noon, and both arrived Friday morning. Planning had to defer its staffing update while it waited.
- 02 **Diego:** I understand the ¹ _____. I knew the reports were late, but I did not realize the staffing update had been held back.
- 03 **Elena:** What prevented Thursday delivery? I have the arrival times, but I do not yet know what happened earlier in the process.
- 04 **Diego:** The source file from regional operations arrived late both weeks. That ² _____ is needed before I can finish the totals; I cannot verify them from the dashboard alone.
- 05 **Elena:** When did you know the file was at risk? I am asking about the timing so we can find a useful point for an earlier update.
- 06 **Diego:** By Wednesday afternoon. I expected it overnight and did not want to send another message without a solution. That left too little ³ _____ for you to help.
- 07 **Elena:** Thank you for explaining. The late file explains the production delay. It does not remove the need to warn us when the deadline is at risk.
- 08 **Diego:** Agreed. I should have ⁴ _____ the missing input on Wednesday instead of waiting for a complete answer. An update could have stated what was missing.
- 09 **Elena:** For the next report, notify me if the source file is missing by Wednesday noon. Name the file, the owner, and the effect on Thursday delivery.
- 10 **Diego:** I can do that. Could you also help address the ⁵ _____ with regional operations? They may not know their delivery time determines ours.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 55.

- 11 **Elena:** Yes. I will speak with their manager and agree a handoff time. I will not promise a new source-file deadline on their behalf before that conversation.
- 12 **Diego:** Then our ⁶ _____ action has two parts: an agreed source handoff and an early-warning message from me if the input is missing.
- 13 **Elena:** Correct. The report remains due Thursday noon unless we explicitly agree otherwise. If the figures cannot be verified, label their status instead of filling the gap with an unsupported number.
- 14 **Diego:** That makes the ⁷ _____ clear. A timely warning is not the same as a completed report, but it lets us decide how to handle the risk.
- 15 **Elena:** Let us test that for the next two reports. If the warning comes earlier but the file is still late, we will know which part needs more work.
- 16 **Diego:** Could we schedule a short Friday ⁸ _____ for those two weeks? That would give us a fixed point to review what happened.
- 17 **Elena:** Yes, ten minutes at 10 a.m. We will use the delivery time and the warning record. If the source file is still late, we will take that evidence to its owner.
- 18 **Diego:** I appreciate the specific approach. When I heard "late reports," I expected a comment about my attitude, not a discussion of ⁹ _____ and the workflow.
- 19 **Elena:** The facts matter more than a label. You have explained the dependency, and we have agreed what each of us will do. I will send that summary today.
- 20 **Diego:** I will confirm it today. You can check my ¹⁰ _____ in the Wednesday warning record and the next two delivery times.

06

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 96

1. impact | 2. upstream input | 3. lead time | 4. flagged | 5. bottleneck | 6. corrective | 7. performance expectation | 8. check-in | 9. observable behavior | 10. follow-through

A missed status update

F Say it

An engineer missed two agreed Tuesday updates. The manager knows the dates but does not know the reason. The next update is still due Tuesday at 2 p.m.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

06

WORD + PHRASE BANK

flag / remains due / prevented / pending

Manager: "The updates were missing on the last two Tuesdays. What
¹ _____ sending them?"

Engineer: "I waited for a full answer. Next time I will ² _____ the unresolved item."

Manager: "The next update ³ _____ Tuesday at 2 p.m."

Engineer: "Understood. I will report what is confirmed and what is still
⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 96

1. prevented | 2. flag | 3. remains due | 4. pending

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-8 and underline the two observed events and their impact. Compare your markings with the facts on the briefing page.
2. Switch roles for turns 9-20. Read the Wednesday trigger and Thursday deadline exactly as printed.
3. Complete the engineer exchange. Read it aloud twice; do not insert a claim about the engineer's attitude.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

One report, two different purposes

A Read the situation

Negotiate a reporting interface, translate local constraints, and define exceptions without weakening oversight.

Headquarters asks the branch to re-enter eighteen figures into a daily spreadsheet. Most figures are already in the shared dashboard, and re-entry takes one hour each day. Ren needs early warning of service failures, not a second archive of every figure. Both offices can agree the format and reporting cadence for this internal process. They cannot change any separate mandatory reporting requirement.

PEOPLE / Nadia: International manager of a US branch | Ren: Headquarters operations manager

07

TRANSLATE THE BUSINESS NEED

Headquarters may experience fewer updates as loss of visibility; a branch may experience repeated requests as distrust. Neither interpretation is established by the request alone. Ask what decision the information supports, then propose a format that serves it. Explain the local workload in measurable terms. Avoid describing one office as "bureaucratic" or the other as "uncooperative" when the real disagreement concerns frequency, evidence, and responsibility.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What does headquarters primarily need?

A A separate archive replacing the shared dashboard

C Early warning of service failures

B A new approval before each figure is entered

D A weekly summary instead of any immediate alert

2. What is the known cost of daily re-entry?

A One hour each day

C One hour each month

B Eighteen hours each day

D No time at all

3. What must remain outside this negotiation?

A The internal spreadsheet layout

C The shared dashboard link

B Separate mandatory reporting requirements

D Who sends the internal update

Answers and explanations: [page 97](#).

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

reporting cadence

How often a report or update is provided.

IN USE agree a reporting cadence

exception reporting

Reporting deviations from agreed conditions rather than every routine item.

IN USE use exception reporting

threshold

A defined point that triggers attention or action.

IN USE set an alert threshold

single source of truth

The agreed authoritative record for a particular set of information.

IN USE maintain a single source of truth

duplicate entry

Recording the same information again in another place.

IN USE eliminate duplicate entry

audit trail

A record that shows changes, actions, or supporting evidence.

IN USE preserve an audit trail

visibility

Access to information needed to understand a situation.

IN USE maintain visibility

local context

Conditions specific to the branch or operating environment.

IN USE explain the local context

handoff

Transfer of information or responsibility between people or teams.

IN USE clarify the handoff

service level

An agreed or defined standard of service performance.

IN USE monitor the service level

reporting burden

The time and effort required to prepare and maintain reports.

IN USE reduce the reporting burden

escalation path

The agreed route for bringing an issue to the right authority.

IN USE follow the escalation path

Precision check

An exception is an event outside a defined condition, not anything someone dislikes. A threshold triggers an action; a cadence sets its rhythm. An audit trail preserves the history rather than replacing it with the latest number.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

reporting line

The management relationship showing whom a person reports to.

IN USE clarify the reporting line

data owner

The role answerable for a defined set of data and its use or maintenance.

IN USE identify the data owner

reporting period

The span of time covered by a report.

IN USE specify the reporting period

refresh cycle

How often information is updated in a system or report.

IN USE confirm the refresh cycle

data lineage

The history of where data came from and how it was transformed.

IN USE trace the data lineage

version control

A method for identifying versions and tracking changes to a record.

IN USE maintain version control

data completeness

The extent to which the required information is present.

IN USE check data completeness

acknowledgment time

The agreed time within which a receiver confirms receipt.

IN USE set an acknowledgment time

operating model

The arrangement of roles, processes, and decision rights used to run the work.

IN USE align the operating model

local discretion

The choices a branch or local team may make within shared requirements.

IN USE define local discretion

cross-functional dependency

Work in one function that depends on an input or decision from another.

IN USE manage a cross-functional dependency

information requirement

The specific information needed for a stated purpose.

IN USE clarify the information requirement

Precision check

A reporting period says which dates the figures cover; a refresh cycle says when they are updated. Data lineage explains origin and transformation; an audit trail records changes or actions. State which history is needed.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

ASK ABOUT USE

"Which decision does each daily figure support?"

PRESERVE THE PURPOSE

"I want to reduce duplication, not reduce your visibility."

DEFINE AN EXCEPTION

"An exception means a missed service target or an unassigned urgent case."

AGREE A HANDOFF

"The branch duty lead will send the alert and name the action owner."

QUANTIFY THE BURDEN

"Re-entering the eighteen figures takes one hour each day."

OFFER A REPORTING DESIGN

"Could we use the dashboard for routine figures and a separate alert for exceptions?"

PROTECT AUTHORITY

"This proposal does not change any separate mandatory report."

TEST THE ARRANGEMENT

"Let us trial the format for two weeks and review missed alerts and preparation time."

Not X, but Y

"Not less visibility, but less duplicate entry" distinguishes the business goal from the proposed method.

Unless + condition

"No separate alert is needed unless the threshold is crossed" sets a condition. It does not mean that routine monitoring stops.

Define before using jargon

Explain "exception reporting" with the actual trigger. Without a trigger, people may use the same term for different practices.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

CHECK DATA FRESHNESS

"As of what time are these figures current?"

NAME THE SOURCE

"Which record should both offices use if the spreadsheet and dashboard disagree?"

SET A RESPONSE EXPECTATION

"Please confirm receipt by the agreed acknowledgment time, even if the issue is unresolved."

DEFINE TIME PRECISELY

"Does the reporting period end at midnight in New York or at headquarters?"

DISTINGUISH REPORTING TERMS

"The reporting line tells us who manages the analyst; the cadence tells us when updates arrive."

LOCATE A CHANGE

"Can we trace that revised figure to its source and see when it changed?"

CLARIFY LOCAL FLEXIBILITY

"Which parts of the format may the branch adapt without changing the shared requirement?"

CLOSE A CROSS-OFFICE GAP

"Let us name an owner on each side of the handoff, including cover for absences."

As of a time

"Current as of 3 p.m. New York time" identifies the information's cutoff. It does not promise that the figure will stay unchanged.

Avoid ambiguous frequency

"Every two weeks" and "twice a week" distinguish meanings that people sometimes attach to "biweekly." State the actual days when timing matters.

Separate receipt from resolution

"We will acknowledge within one hour" promises a response confirming receipt. It does not promise that the issue will be solved within that hour.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Which question discovers the business purpose of the report?

- A** Why is headquarters so controlling?
- B** Which decisions require these daily figures?
- C** Who dislikes the branch?
- D** Can we stop all reports permanently?

2. Which proposal preserves routine access while reducing re-entry?

- A** Remove the dashboard and send no reports.
- B** Hide unfavorable results in a private file.
- C** Keep the dashboard and send defined exception alerts.
- D** Re-enter each figure three times.

3. Which trigger is operationally precise?

- A** When things feel serious
- B** Whenever someone seems worried
- C** At some point after a problem
- D** When a service target is missed or an urgent case has no owner

4. Choose the correct meaning of "unless" here: "Send an alert unless the issue is already logged with an owner."

- A** The logged-and-owned condition is an exception to sending a new alert.
- B** Never monitor a logged issue.
- C** An owner is not needed.
- D** Every alert is automatically approved.

Answers and explanations: [page 97](#).

One report, two different purposes

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

handoff / reporting burden / waiver / audit trail / threshold / visibility / single source of truth / escalation path / duplicate entry / cadence

07

- 01 **Ren:** We need the eighteen branch figures in the daily spreadsheet. When they arrive late, headquarters has less confidence that it can spot a service problem quickly.
- 02 **Nadia:** I understand the need for ¹ _____. May I ask which decision each figure supports? Most of them are already in the shared dashboard.
- 03 **Ren:** The urgent need is to see a missed service target before it becomes a larger problem. The spreadsheet grew over time because different people requested extra columns.
- 04 **Nadia:** That explains the purpose. The current ² _____ takes one hour every day. I would like to remove the repeated work without hiding any figures.
- 05 **Ren:** If we stop receiving the spreadsheet, how will we know whether the dashboard has changed? We cannot watch every branch screen continuously.
- 06 **Nadia:** We could keep the dashboard as the ³ _____ and add a short alert when an agreed condition changes. The alert would link to the actual record.
- 07 **Ren:** What would trigger an alert? I do not want different branches applying different definitions of an exception.
- 08 **Nadia:** Then let us define the ⁴ _____: a missed service target or an urgent case without an assigned owner. Those are the events this internal alert will cover.
- 09 **Ren:** Who will send the alert? I want to avoid a situation in which the analyst assumes the manager has done it and the manager assumes the opposite.
- 10 **Nadia:** The branch duty lead will own the ⁵ _____. The alert will identify the issue, its current owner, and the next update time. A deputy will cover absence.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 64.

- 11 **Ren:** What if the figures change afterward? I still need to see what we knew when the first alert came in.
- 12 **Nadia:** We will preserve an ⁶ _____ in the shared record. The alert will not replace the underlying data or erase earlier values.
- 13 **Ren:** All right. Check for exceptions daily and summarize weekly. That would save me reading the same eighteen figures every morning, too.
- 14 **Nadia:** Let us record that ⁷ _____ explicitly: monitor daily, alert on the defined events, and summarize weekly. A quiet day does not mean monitoring has stopped.
- 15 **Ren:** Agreed, but some reports serve other requirements. I cannot authorize the branch to stop those as part of this conversation.
- 16 **Nadia:** Nor am I asking you to. This is a change to an internal reporting process, not a ⁸ _____ of any separate mandatory requirement.
- 17 **Ren:** Let us trial the arrangement for two weeks. We should compare the time spent preparing updates and check whether any relevant alert was missed.
- 18 **Nadia:** I will record those as the trial criteria. The aim is a lower ⁹ _____ with no loss of the agreed warning function.
- 19 **Ren:** If an alert has no response, send it to me and the duty manager instead of copying everyone. I will make sure the receiving side knows its responsibility.
- 20 **Nadia:** Then we have an ¹⁰ _____ as well as a reporting format. I will send the one-page agreement, and we will confirm the named owners before the trial starts.

07

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 98

1. visibility | 2. duplicate entry | 3. single source of truth | 4. threshold | 5. handoff | 6. audit trail | 7. cadence | 8. waiver | 9. reporting burden | 10. escalation path

A repeated staffing spreadsheet

F Say it

A shared roster already lists confirmed shifts. The office needs a separate alert only when a shift remains unfilled at the agreed checkpoint. Employment and safety requirements remain unchanged.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

07

WORD + PHRASE BANK

alert / handoff / duplication / record

Ren: "Keep the roster as the authoritative ¹ _____."

Nadia: "At the checkpoint, an unfilled shift triggers an ² _____."

Ren: "This change reduces ³ _____, not required safeguards."

Nadia: "We will name an owner and a deputy for the ⁴ _____."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 98

1. record | 2. alert | 3. duplication | 4. handoff

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read the dialogue with Nadia and Ren as equal partners in designing this internal process, not as national stereotypes.
2. Switch roles for turns 7-16. Read the alert threshold, cadence, and limits without dropping any condition.
3. Complete and read the staffing exchange. End by repeating exactly what the new arrangement does not change.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

An apology that changes the next meeting

A Read the situation

Acknowledge a specific impact, separate intent from effect, repair the record, and agree a verifiable change.

Daniel interrupted Lena twice while she explained a customer risk. He then summarized her concern as a timing preference, which was inaccurate. Lena later said she felt dismissed. The risk itself remains unresolved. Daniel wants to repair the interaction and correct the meeting record without making an empty promise that the project decision will go Lena's way.

PEOPLE / Daniel: International project manager | Lena: US-based risk analyst

08

AN EXPLANATION IS NOT AN ERASER

"I was trying to keep us on time" can explain an intention, but it does not undo an interruption or an inaccurate record. Start with what you did and the effect reported by the other person. Then state a concrete repair. The person receiving the apology does not owe instant reassurance. Disagreement about the project may remain after the relationship improves. A useful repair changes the process without promising a predetermined business decision.

Briefing checks

Circle one answer in each item. Use the briefing.

1. What must Daniel correct in the record?

- | | |
|---|---|
| A The office address | B The inaccurate description of Lena's concern |
| C Every project date automatically | D Lena's name |

2. What can a sincere repair legitimately promise?

- | | |
|---|--|
| A Lena will win every future decision. | B No one will disagree again. |
| C A corrected record and a protected turn to explain the risk. | D The risk is already resolved. |

3. What remains open after an apology?

- | | |
|--|---|
| A The actual customer risk | B Whether Daniel interrupted twice |
| C Whether Lena raised a concern | D Whether a meeting occurred |

Answers and explanations: page 99.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 1 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

acknowledge

Recognize an action, fact, or experience explicitly.

IN USE acknowledge the impact

intent

What someone meant or hoped to accomplish.

IN USE explain an intent

impact

What an action actually did or how it affected someone.

IN USE separate intent from impact

defensiveness

Responding mainly to protect oneself from criticism.

IN USE reduce defensiveness

repair

An action that addresses a communication or relationship failure.

IN USE make a concrete repair

retraction

Withdrawal of a statement that should no longer stand.

IN USE issue a retraction

correction

A change that makes a record or statement accurate.

IN USE circulate a correction

mischaracterize

Describe someone's position inaccurately or unfairly.

IN USE mischaracterize a concern

good faith

An honest effort to engage rather than mislead or obstruct.

IN USE act in good faith

commitment

An undertaking to do something specific.

IN USE make a limited commitment

follow-up

Later action to check or continue an agreed step.

IN USE set a follow-up

working agreement

Explicit expectations for how people will cooperate.

IN USE establish a working agreement

Precision check

An explanation describes why something happened; it does not automatically excuse the impact. A correction replaces inaccurate information, while a retraction withdraws a statement. Follow-up checks progress; follow-through carries out the promise.

The vocabulary that does the work

B Find the words / 2 of 2

Read the definitions and say the common word combinations aloud.

ownership

Acceptance that an action or problem is yours to address.

IN USE take ownership of the mistake

omission

Something important left out of a statement or record.

IN USE correct an omission

attribution of credit

Identification of the person whose contribution is being recognized.

IN USE ensure accurate attribution of credit

intent-impact gap

The difference between an intended effect and what actually happened.

IN USE address the intent-impact gap

de-escalation

Reducing the intensity of a conflict without necessarily resolving the issue.

IN USE support de-escalation

face-saving

Allowing someone to preserve dignity while a mistake is addressed.

IN USE offer a face-saving correction

reciprocity

A pattern of responding to another person's constructive action with one of your own.

IN USE build reciprocity over time

remedy

An action intended to put a specific problem right.

IN USE agree a proportionate remedy

corroboration

Additional evidence that supports an account of what happened.

IN USE seek corroboration of the account

non-defensive response

A reply that engages with criticism without immediately protecting or excusing oneself.

IN USE give a non-defensive response

reputational harm

Damage to how others judge a person's competence or reliability.

IN USE address reputational harm

procedural fairness

Fairness in how views are heard and a decision is reached.

IN USE protect procedural fairness

08

Precision check

De-escalation reduces tension; it does not correct an inaccurate record by itself. A remedy names what will put the problem right. Procedural fairness concerns the hearing and decision process, not a guaranteed preferred outcome.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 1 of 2

OWN THE ACTION

"I interrupted you twice and summarized your concern inaccurately."

ACKNOWLEDGE THE EFFECT

"You did not get a fair chance to explain the customer risk."

CORRECT THE RECORD

"I will send a correction to everyone who received the original summary."

AVOID A FALSE OUTCOME PROMISE

"I cannot promise agreement, but I can promise an accurate review."

APOLOGIZE DIRECTLY

"I am sorry I cut you off."

EXPLAIN WITHOUT EXCUSING

"I was trying to manage time; that does not justify misrepresenting your point."

MAKE A PROCESS COMMITMENT

"You will have an uninterrupted turn before we decide."

CHECK THE REPAIR

"After the next meeting, we will check whether the new turn-taking rule was followed."

08

Own the subject

"I interrupted you" names the actor. "Interruptions happened" removes that responsibility from the sentence.

Avoid conditional apologies

"I am sorry if you felt dismissed" makes the reported impact sound doubtful. "I am sorry I cut you off" owns a specific action.

Process versus outcome

"We will review the risk accurately" is a process commitment. "Your recommendation will be approved" promises a result before the review.

Phrases you can actually use

C Notice the language / 2 of 2

OWN AN OMISSION

"I left your contribution out of the summary, and I will correct that."

INVITE A FACTUAL CORRECTION

"Which part of my account is still inaccurate?"

PRESERVE DIGNITY AND ACCURACY

"We can correct the record without making another personal judgment."

SET A VERIFIABLE REMEDY

"I will send the correction to the original recipients by this afternoon."

RESTORE CREDIT

"The revised note will name your contribution and link to the original proposal."

AVOID REQUESTING REASSURANCE

"You do not need to tell me that everything is fine today."

ACKNOWLEDGE REMAINING DISAGREEMENT

"Correcting my account does not require us to agree on the recommendation."

ALLOW TRUST TO DEVELOP

"I understand that trust will depend on what I do in the next meeting."

08

Use a concrete apology

"I am sorry I omitted your contribution" names the action. "I am sorry about everything" leaves the specific error unclear.

Make the remedy visible

"I will make it right" is broad. "I will name your contribution in a correction to the original recipients" specifies an action others can check.

Acknowledge without promising agreement

"I understand the risk you raised" recognizes the concern. "I accept your recommendation" adopts the proposed response. Keep those meanings separate.

Choose the precise message

D Check your understanding

Circle one best answer for each item. Use the stated purpose and case facts, not the option that merely sounds most polite.

1. Choose the apology that owns a specific action.

- A I am sorry you misunderstood my style.
- B Mistakes may have happened somehow.
- C I am sorry if anyone was sensitive.
- D I am sorry I interrupted you twice.

2. Which sentence explains intent without using it as an excuse?

- A I meant well, so there is no problem.
- B I wanted to save time; I still should not have cut you off.
- C My intent cancels the impact.
- D You should have known what I meant.

3. Which commitment is within Daniel's control?

- A The corrected record will restore everyone's trust immediately.
- B Hearing the complete risk explanation will eliminate the risk.
- C I will circulate the correction to the original recipients.
- D A fair hearing guarantees approval of Lena's recommendation.

4. What does restoring trust require here beyond an apology?

- A An accurate record and observable follow-through
- B Immediate forgiveness from Lena
- C A promise never to discuss risk
- D Removal of all disagreement

Answers and explanations: page 99.

An apology that changes the next meeting

E Conversations / turns 1-10

Complete the numbered gaps. Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Cover the answers at the end until you finish.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

follow through / working agreement / follow-up / agreement / correction / mischaracterized / good faith / repair / on the record / intent

08

- 01 **Daniel:** Thank you for meeting with me. Yesterday I interrupted you twice, then described your customer-risk concern as a preference about timing. That description was not accurate.
- 02 **Lena:** It was not. I needed to explain the consequence for the customer, but the summary
1 _____ my concern as a personal preference.
- 03 **Daniel:** I am sorry I cut you off. I was trying to keep the meeting on time, but that does not justify interrupting you or getting the point wrong.
- 04 **Lena:** I can accept that saving time was your 2 _____. The effect was that the group moved on before hearing the risk, and I did not know how to reopen it.
- 05 **Daniel:** That matters. I will send a correction to everyone who received the summary. It will state that you raised an unresolved customer risk, not merely a timing preference.
- 06 **Lena:** Please make that a visible 3 _____, not a quiet edit. Otherwise people who already read the original may continue using the wrong version.
- 07 **Daniel:** Agreed. I will label the correction and link it to the original note. I can also put the risk back on the agenda before the project decision.
- 08 **Lena:** That would be a useful 4 _____. I am not asking you to accept my recommendation automatically; I need the evidence to be heard accurately.
- 09 **Daniel:** At the next meeting, you will have an uninterrupted turn to explain the risk and your proposed response. I will summarize it and ask you to check my wording.
- 10 **Lena:** Then we can separate fair consideration from 5 _____. I may still disagree with the final decision, but at least the group will be deciding on the actual issue.

The conversation, continued

E Conversations / turns 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 73.

- 11 **Daniel:** Yes. I cannot promise the outcome, but I can promise an accurate review. I also want you to be able to say "I have not finished" if I interrupt again.
- 12 **Lena:** I can use that phrase. It will help if the ⁶ _____ applies to everyone, not just to me after this conversation.
- 13 **Daniel:** It will. I will introduce a rule that speakers finish the relevant point before another person responds, except when an urgent safety issue requires immediate interruption.
- 14 **Lena:** Thank you. I do not need a long explanation of why yesterday happened. I need you to ⁷ _____ when the next meeting becomes hurried.
- 15 **Daniel:** That is reasonable. Let us have a five-minute check after the meeting to review whether the rule was followed and whether the risk was recorded correctly.
- 16 **Lena:** That five-minute ⁸ _____ gives us a chance to check what actually happened. I may still need time to feel comfortable raising a difficult point, even if the next meeting goes better.
- 17 **Daniel:** Understood. I am not asking you to say everything is fine. I will send the correction today, and we can check what happens at the next meeting.
- 18 **Lena:** I appreciate that. I am willing to continue in ⁹ _____, while keeping the customer risk on the table until the group has reviewed it.
- 19 **Daniel:** Then I will send the corrected note today and give you the agenda slot before the decision. Please check the factual wording when it arrives.
- 20 **Lena:** I will. Let us put those steps ¹⁰ _____: a visible correction, an uninterrupted explanation, and a check afterward. That is more useful than a promise that we will never disagree.

08

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 100

1. mischaracterized | 2. intent | 3. correction | 4. repair | 5. agreement | 6. working agreement | 7. follow through | 8. follow-up | 9. good faith | 10. on the record

Restoring credit for an idea

F Say it

Daniel presented Lena's process idea without naming her contribution. The audience may now think it was his idea. He can correct the attribution in the same project channel.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

attribution / acknowledging / commitment / omission

08

Daniel: "I presented your idea without ¹ _____ your contribution."

Lena: "Please correct the ² _____ in the same project channel."

Daniel: "I will name your contribution explicitly and link to your original note. That is my ³ _____."

Lena: "Thank you. I will check the corrected note; that does not mean the original ⁴ _____ did not matter."

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 100

1. acknowledging | 2. attribution | 3. commitment | 4. omission

Rehearse with a fixed script

1. Read turns 1-8, emphasizing the action Daniel owns and the visible correction he promises. Do not add "if you were offended."
2. Switch roles for turns 9-20. Keep the distinction between an accurate review and a guaranteed outcome.
3. Complete the attribution exchange and read it twice. Finish by naming the concrete promised action, using only the printed facts.

WORKING ALONE

Read both roles, pausing for two seconds when the speaker changes. Repeat with the bank covered, then check any missed expressions.

Two urgent launches and one shared analyst

E More workplace conversations / 1-10

Negotiate priorities upward without making an impossible commitment.

The US branch has one analyst available for six days next week. The renewal review needs four days; a new launch needs four. The director can change priorities but has not approved extra staffing.

PEOPLE / Mina: Branch manager | Alex: Regional director

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Answers follow turn 20.

09

WORD + PHRASE BANK

trade-off / reopen / reprioritize / point of contact / sign-off / first pass

- 01 **Alex:** Can your team add the launch analysis next week? Sales needs it by Friday.
- 02 **Mina:** We can take it on if we ¹ _____. Which deliverable should move?
- 03 **Alex:** I wasn't asking you to move anything. The renewal review still matters.
- 04 **Mina:** Understood. Together they need eight analyst days. We have six, even with my team taking over the presentation.
- 05 **Alex:** Could the analyst just push a little harder?
- 06 **Mina:** She's already covering an absence. I can ask about the estimate, but I won't commit her to eight days of work in six.
- 07 **Alex:** All right. What's the smallest useful launch analysis?
- 08 **Mina:** A two-day ² _____ covering our two largest customer groups. It would exclude the regional breakdown.
- 09 **Alex:** Sales will ask for that breakdown immediately.
- 10 **Mina:** Then we need to choose. I recommend protecting the renewal review and sending the smaller launch analysis on Friday.

The conversation, continued

E More workplace conversations / 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 76.

- 11 **Alex:** Why put renewals first?
- 12 **Mina:** Three contracts come up for review Monday. The launch decision is still two weeks away. That's the ³ _____.
- 13 **Alex:** That makes sense. Can you promise the rest by Tuesday?
- 14 **Mina:** Wednesday is the date I can support. Tuesday would depend on work we haven't scoped yet.
- 15 **Alex:** Let's use Wednesday. I need you to manage Sales' expectations.
- 16 **Mina:** I will. Can I say we have your ⁴ _____ on the reduced Friday scope?
- 17 **Alex:** Yes. Copy me on the message, and I'll back the decision if they challenge it.
- 18 **Mina:** Thanks. I'll send the scope and dates today. If a new request comes in, we'll ⁵ _____ the priority discussion.
- 19 **Alex:** Agreed. I don't want the analyst negotiating this alone.
- 20 **Mina:** Neither do I. I'll be the ⁶ _____ for changes, and she'll focus on the analysis.

09

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 101

1. reprioritize | 2. first pass | 3. trade-off | 4. sign-off | 5. reopen | 6. point of contact

A request arrives after the agreement

F Say it in a new situation

Sales now requests a third customer group in Friday's initial analysis. Mina needs Alex to choose between adding it and retaining the agreed deadline.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

outside / confirm / replace / deadline

09

Mina: A third group is ¹ _____ the Friday scope we agreed.

Alex: Can we include it without moving the ² _____?

Mina: Only if we ³ _____ one of the original two groups.

Alex: Keep the original two. I'll ⁴ _____ that decision with Sales.

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 101

1. outside | 2. deadline | 3. replace | 4. confirm

Read, switch, repeat

1. Check the four answers and read the complete exchange aloud.
2. Switch roles. Read it again with the word bank covered.
3. Return to the extended conversation. Read turns 1-10, then switch roles for turns 11-20. Use the corrected expressions.

SOLO PRACTICE

Read both roles. Pause briefly at each change of speaker. Repeat any line that needed an answer check.

When praise leaves out the people who did the work

E More workplace conversations / 1-10

Address recognition and attribution without guessing a colleague's motives.

A project sponsor praised a manager for an improved onboarding process. Three team members designed and tested it. The manager accepted the praise without naming them; a team lead raises the omission privately.

PEOPLE / Sam: Team lead | Elena: Department manager

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Answers follow turn 20.

10

WORD + PHRASE BANK

routine / attribution / spotlight / omission / take credit / follow-up

- 01 **Sam:** Do you have five minutes about the sponsor's update?
- 02 **Elena:** Sure. I thought it went well. Was something inaccurate?
- 03 **Sam:** The results were right. But when she thanked you for designing the process, you didn't mention Noor, Luis, or Priya.
- 04 **Elena:** I didn't mean to ¹ _____ for their work. I thought everyone knew it was a team effort.
- 05 **Sam:** The sponsor doesn't work with them. They heard the update and felt their contribution had disappeared.
- 06 **Elena:** Thanks for telling me. What would put that right without making the next meeting awkward?
- 07 **Sam:** A short ² _____ naming what each person did would help.
- 08 **Elena:** I can do that. Noor built the checklist, Luis ran the trial, and Priya gathered feedback. Have I got that right?
- 09 **Sam:** Yes. And Luis also trained the first group of supervisors.
- 10 **Elena:** I'll include that. I'd like to give them the floor at next month's review.

The conversation, continued

E More workplace conversations / 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 79.

11 **Sam:** Please ask them first. Priya would rather share the customer findings with Noor than present alone.

12 **Elena:** Fair point. Recognition shouldn't become an unexpected
3 _____.

13 **Sam:** Exactly. I don't want us to assume everyone wants the same kind of praise.

14 **Elena:** Would you check whether they'd prefer to present together?

15 **Sam:** I can ask, but the invitation should come from you. That will make the
4 _____ clearer.

16 **Elena:** You're right. I'll send the correction today and speak with them tomorrow.

17 **Sam:** Thank you. I worried this might sound like a complaint about you personally.

18 **Elena:** You raised a specific ⁵ _____. I needed to hear it.

19 **Sam:** Then let's add contributors' names to future project updates before they go out.

20 **Elena:** Agreed. I'll own the final check and make that part of our
6 _____.

10

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 102

1. take credit | 2. follow-up | 3. spotlight | 4. attribution | 5. omission | 6. routine

Correcting the public record

F Say it in a new situation

Elena calls the sponsor before sending a written correction. The sponsor has not yet shared the results with the executive team.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

revised / omission / figures / contributors

Elena: Before you circulate the results, I need to correct an ¹ _____ in yesterday's update.

Sponsor: Do we need to change the ² _____ themselves?

Elena: No. Please add the three ³ _____ and their specific roles.

Sponsor: Send me the wording and I'll use the ⁴ _____ version.

10

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 102

1. omission | 2. figures | 3. contributors | 4. revised

Read, switch, repeat

1. Check the four answers and read the complete exchange aloud.
2. Switch roles. Read it again with the word bank covered.
3. Return to the extended conversation. Read turns 1-10, then switch roles for turns 11-20. Use the corrected expressions.

SOLO PRACTICE

Read both roles. Pause briefly at each change of speaker. Repeat any line that needed an answer check.

Reversing a decision without undermining the team

E More workplace conversations / 1-10

Explain a changed decision, acknowledge its cost, and define what remains valid.

A branch manager approved a Monday software launch. A test completed Thursday reveals that customers cannot retrieve some older records. The technical lead recommends postponement. Customer messages are prepared but have not been sent.

PEOPLE / Omar: Branch manager | Grace: Technical lead

Use each bank entry once, without changing its form. Answers follow turn 20.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

narrow down / invalidate / decision point / release criteria / make the call / hold off

11

- 01 **Omar:** You asked to revisit Monday. What's changed since yesterday?
- 02 **Grace:** The archive test failed. Current records load correctly, but some older records don't. We need to ¹ _____ on the launch.
- 03 **Omar:** I told the leadership team the date was settled.
- 04 **Grace:** I know. We didn't have this result then. I'm asking you to change the decision because the evidence changed.
- 05 **Omar:** Could we launch and warn customers about older records?
- 06 **Grace:** Some use those records to complete daily work. Support doesn't have a reliable workaround yet.
- 07 **Omar:** How long will the fix take?
- 08 **Grace:** I can't give you that date today. By tomorrow noon, we can ² _____ the cause and estimate the repair.
- 09 **Omar:** Then I need a message today that doesn't sound as though the team missed an obvious check.
- 10 **Grace:** We can state when the test ran and what it found. The test was scheduled before release for this reason.

The conversation, continued

E More workplace conversations / 11-20

Continue with the word bank on page 82.

- 11 **Omar:** You're right. I shouldn't turn this into a search for someone to blame.
- 12 **Grace:** The immediate ³ _____ is whether to send the launch messages.
- 13 **Omar:** Don't send them. I'll explain the postponement to leadership myself.
- 14 **Grace:** Thank you. Can we keep the completed training and documentation work?
- 15 **Omar:** Yes. This doesn't ⁴ _____ those deliverables. Update only what the fix changes.
- 16 **Grace:** I'll tell the team that. They're likely to hear postponement as starting again.
- 17 **Omar:** Let's be explicit: the release is paused, not abandoned. What will you bring tomorrow?
- 18 **Grace:** The cause we can support, the repair estimate, and the ⁵ _____ we still need to satisfy.
- 19 **Omar:** Good. I'll book the review and explain that the next date depends on those checks.
- 20 **Grace:** I'll send the evidence first so we can use the meeting to ⁶ _____, not reconstruct the timeline.

11

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 103

1. hold off | 2. narrow down | 3. decision point | 4. invalidate | 5. release criteria | 6. make the call

A colleague asks whether everything is cancelled

F Say it in a new situation

A supervisor has heard about the postponement and wants to cancel the training records and support preparation.

Complete the four gaps. Use each bank entry once.

WORD + PHRASE BANK

paused / checkpoint / dependencies / plan

Supervisor: Should I cancel the whole launch ¹ _____?

Omar: No. The release is ² _____ while the archive issue is investigated.

Supervisor: I'll retain the completed work and flag any ³ _____ on the fix.

Omar: Exactly. We'll review the remaining criteria at tomorrow's ⁴ _____.

11

ANSWERS / EXPLANATIONS: PAGE 103

1. plan | 2. paused | 3. dependencies | 4. checkpoint

Read, switch, repeat

1. Check the four answers and read the complete exchange aloud.
2. Switch roles. Read it again with the word bank covered.
3. Return to the extended conversation. Read turns 1-10, then switch roles for turns 11-20. Use the corrected expressions.

SOLO PRACTICE

Read both roles. Pause briefly at each change of speaker. Repeat any line that needed an answer check.

01 Briefing and language checks

Check meaning before assuming agreement

A Briefing checks / page 4

1. Which point is confirmed before the conversation?

B. Six people are trained.

The briefing confirms six trained people; the additional two are not yet confirmed.

2. Who can authorize the branch launch after the check?

C. Aiko

Aiko owns this decision. Jordan supplies the staffing information.

3. What needs clarification?

A. Whether "fine" approved the date or only the general plan

The immediate ambiguity is the scope of "fine." Scheduled training, acknowledged minutes and confirmation of wording do not establish readiness or transfer launch authority.

D Language checks / page 9

1. Choose the question that checks authorization, not receipt.

C. Have you authorized the Monday launch?

Authorization is permission to act; receiving or reading the plan does not provide it.

2. Complete: "Could you clarify whether ___?"

B. the date is final

An embedded question uses subject + verb: "the date is final."

3. Choose the record supported by the briefing.

D. Monday is provisional pending a staffing check.

The final staffing level is unknown, so the record must preserve the condition.

4. Which collocation means to settle an outstanding requirement?

A. resolve a dependency

A dependency is resolved when the required condition or preceding work is settled.

01 Conversation answers

Check meaning before assuming agreement

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 10-11

1. green light. Turn 2. Giving the green light means allowing an action to proceed. The printed "the" completes the phrase. Jordan supported the sequence but did not approve Monday.

2. conditional. Turn 4. Support depends on having eight trained people. Jordan accepts the approach only if that condition is met.

3. unconfirmed. Turn 6. A scheduled assessment does not establish extra capacity. Its outcome remains unknown.

4. certify. Turn 8. Jordan can obtain or discuss results but cannot formally attest to them. The sentence limits authority, not communication.

5. flag. Turn 10. To flag an item is to draw attention to it. Jordan cannot approve or resolve a missing result, and should not minimize it.

6. acknowledgment. Turn 12. "Understood" can acknowledge a message without approving it. The minutes need to preserve that distinction.

7. reservation. Turn 14. Having a reservation means having a concern or qualification. It need not mean rejecting the whole plan.

8. read-back. Turn 16. Aiko restates the agreement for confirmation. She is not predicting an outcome, referring a dispute upward, or removing a requirement.

9. authorization. Turn 18. Authorization is permission to act. Jordan can check the wording; only Aiko can authorize the launch after the staffing check.

10. still provisional. Turn 20. The date remains conditional. None of the evidence makes it final, irrelevant, or guaranteed.

F Transfer conversation

Page 12

1. positive feedback on the demonstration

Aiko: "The team likes the interface. May I record that as positive feedback on the demonstration?"

The team evaluated a demonstration; neither review nor purchase is complete.

2. subject to

Jordan: "Yes, but the purchase remains subject to security review."

"Subject to" makes review a condition, not something to bypass.

3. approval authority

Aiko: "Who has approval authority for the contract?"

The question asks who is entitled to approve the purchase.

4. constitute

Jordan: "The purchasing director. Our positive feedback does not constitute that approval."

"Constitute" means count as. Feedback may precede approval, but does not itself amount to approval.

02 Briefing and language checks

Challenge ideas respectfully

A Briefing checks / page 13

1. Which assumption is contradicted by the previous trial?

C. Follow-up will take two hours.

The trial used four hours, which challenges the two-hour estimate.

2. Which adjustment is within Mei's stated authority?

B. Change the number of pilot accounts.

The briefing gives Mei discretion over account count, not additional staffing.

3. Which response separates the issue from the person?

A. Ask for the challenged assumption and supporting evidence.

A specific evidence request tests the proposal without inventing a personal motive.

D Language checks / page 18

1. Choose the response that concedes a fact but preserves a narrower proposal.

B. I accept the four-hour figure; a smaller pilot may still fit.

The response accepts the evidence while leaving the account count open to revision.

2. Complete: "The previous trial ___ a workload risk; it does not prove failure."

D. indicates

"Indicates" signals evidence of risk without claiming certainty.

3. Which sentence sets a conduct boundary without rejecting criticism?

C. Please keep the comments on the proposal, not the people.

It protects people while allowing substantive disagreement.

4. Which question asks for a counterproposal within the constraint?

A. How many accounts can two managers support?

Asking how many accounts two managers can support seeks an option within the fixed staffing allocation. The alternatives assume unsupported improvement, add unauthorized capacity, or overstate the earlier evidence.

02 Conversation answers

Challenge ideas respectfully

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 19-20

1. premise. Turn 2. A premise is a starting assumption. Mei asks which assumption in the plan Chris is challenging.

2. evidence gap. Turn 4. The estimate lacks supporting evidence. Neither approval nor extra staffing has been established, and motives remain unknown.

3. concede. Turn 6. Mei accepts the template point. She does not reject, ignore, or delay that acknowledgment.

4. scrutiny. Turn 8. Scrutiny means close examination of the work. Mei welcomes that examination while setting a boundary around personal judgments.

5. impact. Turn 10. The focus is how the wording affected others, not a legal judgment or a vote on the wording.

6. counterproposal. Turn 12. Chris offers an alternative design. He neither grants approval nor demands unconditional compliance.

7. validate. Turn 14. The smaller sample cannot establish that a full rollout is justified. It may precede or inform a later decision.

8. non-negotiable. Turn 16. Two managers is a fixed constraint for this decision. The account count and review points can still change.

9. retain. Turn 18. The team can keep a substantive disagreement while correcting the personal remark. It need not hide or resolve the design issue immediately.

10. stress-test. Turn 20. The revised pilot will examine the assumption under real workload. Announcing an estimate does not test it.

F Transfer conversation

Page 21

1. confirmations

Chris: "The forecast is optimistic. Which confirmations support ten renewals?"

A claim of confirmed renewals needs customer confirmations.

2. can substantiate

Mei: "I can substantiate seven confirmed renewals, not ten."

"Substantiate" means support with evidence; seven is the supported figure.

3. possible

Chris: "Then label the other three as possible, not committed."

The three renewals are possibilities, not established commitments.

4. assumption

Mei: "Agreed. We will challenge the assumption, not the forecaster's character."

The disagreement concerns the estimate and its basis, not a personal characteristic.

03 Briefing and language checks

Make authority and participation clear

A Briefing checks / page 22

1. Which decision can Sofia delegate in this case?

C. Internal task order

Only internal task order is within the stated delegation.

2. What remains reserved to Sofia?

B. Customer promises and extra spending

The briefing identifies these two approval boundaries.

3. How long will the process trial run?

D. Two weeks

The trial has a defined two-week period, after which the process can be reviewed.

D Language checks / page 27

1. Which instruction delegates authority with a clear boundary?

D. Reorder internal tasks; seek approval before changing customer promises.

It names both the delegated area and the reserved decision.

2. Complete: "You ___ notify me if a change affects a customer promise." The requirement is compulsory.

B. must

"Must" expresses the compulsory notification stated in the question.

3. Which statement describes consultation, not approval?

A. Finance supplies cost information before Sofia decides.

Supplying input is consultation; the other choices exercise decision authority.

4. The team disagrees after everyone has contributed. What is still possible?

C. Sofia can decide after considering the input.

Participation and disagreement do not remove Sofia's assigned decision rights. Neither consultation nor trial coordination expands Alex's spending authority.

03 Conversation answers

Make authority and participation clear

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 28-29

- 1. decision rights.** Turn 2. The missing information is who may decide which matters.
- 2. delegated.** Turn 4. Sofia grants Alex authority for a defined period and scope.
- 3. remit.** Turn 6. A remit is an assigned area of authority or work.
- 4. exception.** Turn 8. A purchase falls outside the normal permission granted here.
- 5. consulted.** Turn 10. Support provides input; Alex remains the decision owner for the internal sequence.
- 6. discretion.** Turn 12. Discretion is the freedom to choose within the agreed limits.
- 7. accountability.** Turn 14. Sofia keeps responsibility for oversight and support while Alex coordinates the work.
- 8. responsibilities.** Turn 16. Knowing the actual duties matters more than memorizing the letters in a role map.
- 9. escalation threshold.** Turn 18. The threshold identifies when Alex must take a proposed decision back to Sofia.
- 10. review.** Turn 20. The two-week checkpoint evaluates the trial; it does not automatically approve continuation.

F Transfer conversation

Page 30

1. may

Sofia: "You may choose the room within the approved budget."

"May" grants the specific permission described.

2. seek your approval

Alex: "If every suitable room costs more, I will seek your approval before booking."

A higher cost is outside the delegation, so approval must come before booking.

3. my decision

Sofia: "Changing the event date remains my decision."

Sofia expressly reserves the date decision.

4. approval boundary

Alex: "I will record the budget and the approval boundary so the team knows when to contact you."

The boundary explains which decisions need Sofia's approval.

04 Briefing and language checks

Negotiate realistic commitments

04

A Briefing checks / page 31

1. What can Omar supply on Friday?

B. A labeled estimate

The Friday deliverable is an estimate, not verified data.

2. What cannot Priya change simply by choosing an option?

C. The reconciliation completion constraint

Choosing an option does not make the missing check complete sooner.

3. Which wording preserves both the Friday deliverable and its time reference?

D. A provisional estimate Friday at 3 p.m. New York time

The agreed Friday output is provisional and the supplied clock reference is New York. The other choices change either its verification status or its time reference.

D Language checks / page 36

1. Choose the commitment supported by the facts.

C. We can send a labeled estimate Friday at 3 p.m. New York time.

Only the labeled Friday estimate matches the stated capacity.

2. Complete the ordinary future condition: "If you ____ the estimate option, we can meet Friday."

A. choose

Use present simple in this conditional clause: "If you choose."

3. Which caveat preserves the status of the Friday figures?

B. Provisional; reconciliation pending

It states both the limitation and the outstanding check.

4. Which reply clarifies purpose before negotiating the deliverable?

D. Is Friday's decision about planning capacity or final reporting?

The needed decision helps determine whether an estimate can serve the meeting.

04 Conversation answers

Negotiate realistic commitments

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 37-38

- 1. deliverable.** Turn 2. The distinction is between two outputs: an estimate and a verified report.
- 2. reconciliation.** Turn 4. Comparing supplier records and resolving differences is reconciliation.
- 3. caveat.** Turn 6. The estimate needs a stated limitation, not an assurance that it is final.
- 4. provisional.** Turn 8. The visible label must show that the figure is not yet final.
- 5. provided that.** Turn 10. The delivery promise depends on unchanged scope; this phrase states that condition.
- 6. scope creep.** Turn 12. Adding two branches would expand the agreed work after the deadline was set.
- 7. commit.** Turn 14. "Commit to" names the undertaking Omar can make: explaining a difference.
- 8. trade-off.** Turn 16. The team exchanges early availability for provisional rather than verified information.
- 9. contingency.** Turn 18. The fallback is a status update if the expected supplier check is delayed.
- 10. guarantee.** Turn 20. The Friday number must not be understood as an assurance of the eventual result.

F Transfer conversation

Page 39

1. internal

Priya: "Can you deliver ten slides Tuesday?" Omar: "Yes, as an internal draft."

An internal draft is available; external release must wait for review.

2. until

Priya: "Can the client receive it then?" Omar: "Not until compliance grants clearance."

"Not until" makes actual clearance a condition of release; a scheduled review date does not establish approval.

3. review pending

Priya: "Then I will call Tuesday's file review pending."

The label accurately preserves the outstanding review.

4. clears

Omar: "If compliance clears the version Wednesday, we can prepare it for release."

The future condition takes present simple: "clears." The action depends on actual clearance, not merely completion of a review.

05 Briefing and language checks

Include every voice in a meeting

A Briefing checks / page 40

1. Whose input has been missed?

B. Arun's routing concern

Arun posted a concern in chat without receiving a response.

2. What blocks a final go-live decision?

C. An unfinished routing check

The check is a stated prerequisite and is not complete.

3. Who owns the go-live decision?

A. Leila

The meeting chair also holds the decision authority in this case.

D Language checks / page 45

1. Choose the intervention that protects the interrupted speaker.

C. Arun has not finished; Ben will speak next.

It preserves Arun's turn and gives Ben a predictable next turn.

2. Which paraphrase does not add an unsupported conclusion?

B. Arun said the routing check is incomplete.

It restates the known information without inferring motive or approval.

3. Which action belongs in a decision log?

D. Go-live pending; Arun checks routing; Leila decides afterward.

It records status, work ownership, and decision authority accurately.

4. Which issue must not be parked before this go-live decision?

A. The unfinished routing check

Routing is the stated go-live prerequisite. The other improvements are not supplied as conditions for this decision.

05 Conversation answers

Include every voice in a meeting

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 46-47

1. crosstalk. Turn 2. Overlapping voices prevented the remote contribution from being heard.

2. the floor. Turn 4. Ben explicitly gives Arun the opportunity to speak to the group.

3. paraphrase. Turn 6. Leila restates the distinction and asks Arun to verify it.

4. parking lot. Turn 9. The slide layout is deferred; the prerequisite routing issue is not.

5. decision. Turn 12. Leila retains authority to approve the switch.

6. timebox. Turn 14. A short protected period gives Arun space to finish without letting the meeting drift.

7. action items. Turn 16. Ben takes responsibility for two specific follow-up tasks.

8. dissent. Turn 18. Arun opposes final approval today, not the entire project.

9. decision log. Turn 20. This record distinguishes a pending decision from assigned work.

10. asynchronous input. Turn 20. Colleagues can contribute in the shared note without joining the live meeting.

F Transfer conversation

Page 48

1. the floor

Chair: "Nora has raised her hand. Let us give her the floor."

The floor is the chance to speak, not decision authority.

2. pending

Nora: "The attachment is missing; approval is still pending."

The missing prerequisite means approval has not yet been completed.

3. paraphrase

Chair: "I will paraphrase your point: we need the attachment before approval."

The chair restates the meaning rather than adding a new conclusion.

4. decision log

Nora: "Correct. Please record that in the decision log."

The log should preserve the outstanding approval condition.

05

06 Briefing and language checks

Give specific, useful feedback

A Briefing checks / page 49

1. Which statement describes an observation?

C. The last two reports arrived Friday morning.

Arrival dates are observable; the other statements infer motives or overgeneralize.

2. What operational effect is known?

A. Planning deferred its staffing update.

Only the deferred staffing update is supplied by the case.

3. What should Elena avoid assuming before asking?

B. The cause of the delay.

The timing and dependency are known; the reason for lateness is not.

D Language checks / page 54

1. Which opening is specific and evidence-based?

D. The last two reports arrived Friday, after Thursday's noon deadline.

Naming the two Friday arrivals and Thursday deadline identifies the observed events and agreed standard. The alternatives assert an unestablished cause, motivation, or broader pattern.

2. Which question does not assume fault or motive?

B. What prevented the Thursday delivery?

The question leaves the cause open for an evidence-based explanation.

3. Choose the early-warning trigger.

C. If the source file is missing Wednesday noon, notify me that day.

It specifies both a condition and a time for action.

4. Which statement preserves the expectation while offering support?

A. I will address the handoff; you still need to flag missing input early.

Support for the dependency does not remove the analyst's communication responsibility.

06 Conversation answers

Give specific, useful feedback

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 55-56

- 1. impact.** Turn 2. The delayed staffing update is the operational effect of the late reports.
- 2. upstream input.** Turn 4. The source file is required from an earlier part of the workflow.
- 3. lead time.** Turn 6. An earlier warning would create time for Elena to help before the deadline.
- 4. flagged.** Turn 8. Flagging identifies the missing input and its risk without pretending to have solved it.
- 5. bottleneck.** Turn 10. The late source-file handoff limits the speed of the downstream report.
- 6. corrective.** Turn 12. The adjective completes "corrective action." Both steps address a known problem: the late handoff and the missing warning.
- 7. performance expectation.** Turn 14. Elena states the deadline, warning trigger, and accuracy requirement explicitly.
- 8. check-in.** Turn 16. A brief scheduled review is a check-in, not a new approval process.
- 9. observable behavior.** Turn 18. Arrival times and warning messages can be observed; an attitude label guesses at motive.
- 10. follow-through.** Turn 20. The participants must now carry out the actions they agreed.

F Transfer conversation

Page 57

1. prevented

Manager: "The updates were missing on the last two Tuesdays. What prevented sending them?"

The question asks for a cause without assuming a motive.

2. flag

Engineer: "I waited for a full answer. Next time I will flag the unresolved item."

A status update can identify what is unresolved rather than wait for completion.

3. remains due

Manager: "The next update remains due Tuesday at 2 p.m."

The conversation has not changed the agreed deadline.

4. pending

Engineer: "Understood. I will report what is confirmed and what is still pending."

"Pending" preserves the distinction between completed and unresolved work.

07 Briefing and language checks

Coordinate across offices

A Briefing checks / page 58

1. What does headquarters primarily need?

C. Early warning of service failures

Ren explicitly needs early warning of service failures. The other arrangements are not the stated business purpose and could delay or duplicate the information.

2. What is the known cost of daily re-entry?

A. One hour each day

The case specifies one hour per day; eighteen is the number of figures.

3. What must remain outside this negotiation?

B. Separate mandatory reporting requirements

The participants may redesign this internal process, not waive separate requirements.

D Language checks / page 63

1. Which question discovers the business purpose of the report?

B. Which decisions require these daily figures?

It asks how the data will be used without assuming a motive.

2. Which proposal preserves routine access while reducing re-entry?

C. Keep the dashboard and send defined exception alerts.

The dashboard supplies routine visibility; explicit alerts draw attention to deviations.

3. Which trigger is operationally precise?

D. When a service target is missed or an urgent case has no owner

It identifies observable conditions rather than a subjective mood.

4. Choose the correct meaning of "unless" here: "Send an alert unless the issue is already logged with an owner."

A. The logged-and-owned condition is an exception to sending a new alert.

"Unless" introduces the condition under which the stated action is not required.

07 Conversation answers

Coordinate across offices

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 64-65

- 1. visibility.** Turn 2. Headquarters needs access to information about branch service performance.
- 2. duplicate entry.** Turn 4. The figures are being manually recorded again even though they are already available.
- 3. single source of truth.** Turn 6. The shared dashboard remains the agreed authoritative record, rather than competing spreadsheets.
- 4. threshold.** Turn 8. The missed target or unassigned urgent case defines when an alert is required.
- 5. handoff.** Turn 10. The duty lead transfers the information with an owner and an update time.
- 6. audit trail.** Turn 12. A history of data and changes lets the offices reconstruct what was known.
- 7. cadence.** Turn 14. Daily monitoring, event-triggered alerts, and weekly summaries define the rhythm of reporting.
- 8. waiver.** Turn 16. A waiver would remove a requirement; this internal redesign does not do that.
- 9. reporting burden.** Turn 18. The trial aims to reduce preparation time while preserving useful information.
- 10. escalation path.** Turn 20. Ren names the route to use when an alert has not received a response.

F Transfer conversation

Page 66

1. record

Ren: "Keep the roster as the authoritative record."

The roster is the agreed record of confirmed shifts.

2. alert

Nadia: "At the checkpoint, an unfilled shift triggers an alert."

The defined exception needs an alert, not assumed approval.

3. duplication

Ren: "This change reduces duplication, not required safeguards."

The aim is less repeated administration while retaining the safeguards.

4. handoff

Nadia: "We will name an owner and a deputy for the handoff."

Naming a sender and backup makes the information transfer reliable.

07

08 Briefing and language checks

Repair misunderstandings and build trust

A Briefing checks / page 67

1. What must Daniel correct in the record?

B. The inaccurate description of Lena's concern

He described a customer risk as a timing preference.

2. What can a sincere repair legitimately promise?

C. A corrected record and a protected turn to explain the risk.

Daniel can change the process and record without promising a business outcome.

3. What remains open after an apology?

A. The actual customer risk

Repairing the interaction does not itself resolve the substantive risk.

D Language checks / page 72

1. Choose the apology that owns a specific action.

D. I am sorry I interrupted you twice.

The speaker accepts responsibility for an observable action without shifting blame.

2. Which sentence explains intent without using it as an excuse?

B. I wanted to save time; I still should not have cut you off.

The explanation does not remove responsibility for the interruption.

3. Which commitment is within Daniel's control?

C. I will circulate the correction to the original recipients.

Daniel can circulate his correction. Trust, elimination of the risk, and the eventual business decision are not guaranteed by that action.

4. What does restoring trust require here beyond an apology?

A. An accurate record and observable follow-through

The repair is demonstrated by actions; it does not require instant forgiveness or agreement.

08 Conversation answers

Repair misunderstandings and build trust

E Dialogue gaps

Pages 73-74

- 1. mischaracterized.** Turn 2. The summary inaccurately turned a customer risk into a personal timing preference.
- 2. intent.** Turn 4. Saving time explains the intended purpose; it does not erase the effect.
- 3. correction.** Turn 6. The original recipients need an explicit accurate replacement, not an unnoticed edit.
- 4. repair.** Turn 8. Correcting the record and reopening the issue address the specific communication failure.
- 5. agreement.** Turn 10. A fair hearing does not require the decision maker to accept the recommendation.
- 6. working agreement.** Turn 12. The turn-taking rule should be an explicit norm for the whole group.
- 7. follow through.** Turn 14. After "need you to," use the verb phrase "follow through." Lena wants Daniel to carry out his promise when time pressure returns.
- 8. follow-up.** Turn 16. The later five-minute check tests whether the repair was put into practice.
- 9. good faith.** Turn 18. Lena offers an honest willingness to continue without claiming instant trust or agreement.
- 10. on the record.** Turn 20. Putting the steps on the record makes the agreed actions explicit and available for later checking.

F Transfer conversation

Page 75

1. acknowledging

Daniel: "I presented your idea without acknowledging your contribution."

The failure was to recognize Lena's contribution.

2. attribution

Lena: "Please correct the attribution in the same project channel."

Attribution identifies who contributed the idea.

3. commitment

Daniel: "I will name your contribution explicitly and link to your original note. That is my commitment."

He promises an action within his control.

4. omission

Lena: "Thank you. I will check the corrected note; that does not mean the original omission did not matter."

The omission is the failure to name the contribution; a repair does not erase its significance.

08

09 Conversation answers

Two urgent launches and one shared analyst

E Extended conversation

Pages 76-77

1. reprioritize. Turn 2. Reprioritize means change the order of importance when available capacity cannot cover everything.

2. first pass. Turn 8. A first pass is an initial review, not the complete analysis requested originally.

3. trade-off. Turn 12. Trade-off names the competing benefits and costs of choosing one priority over another.

4. sign-off. Turn 16. Sign-off means explicit approval of this revised priority and delivery plan.

5. reopen. Turn 18. Reopen means return to a decision for further discussion rather than silently adding more work.

6. point of contact. Turn 20. Point of contact identifies the person who will receive questions and coordinate follow-up.

F Transfer exchange

Page 78

1. outside

Mina: A third group is outside the Friday scope we agreed.

Outside marks the request as additional work rather than an existing commitment.

2. deadline

Alex: Can we include it without moving the deadline?

Deadline identifies the agreed delivery time that the additional work could affect.

3. replace

Mina: Only if we replace one of the original two groups.

Replace means substitute one group for another instead of adding a third.

4. confirm

Alex: Keep the original two. I'll confirm that decision with Sales.

Confirm means communicate the agreed decision clearly to the affected team.

10 Conversation answers

When praise leaves out the people who did the work

E Extended conversation

Pages 79-80

1. take credit. Turn 4. Take credit means accept recognition for work or an achievement, including work done by others.

2. follow-up. Turn 7. A follow-up is a later message or action that addresses an earlier exchange.

3. spotlight. Turn 12. Spotlight means concentrated public attention; here it could make an employee uncomfortable.

4. attribution. Turn 15. Attribution identifies who produced particular work rather than crediting only the manager.

5. omission. Turn 18. Omission means something left out; here it is the contributors' names and work.

6. routine. Turn 20. Routine means an established repeated practice, not a one-time response to this incident.

F Transfer exchange

Page 81

1. omission

Elena: Before you circulate the results, I need to correct an omission in yesterday's update.

Omission identifies information that was left out without inventing a motive.

2. figures

Sponsor: Do we need to change the figures themselves?

Figures means the numerical results, which the scenario says are accurate.

3. contributors

Elena: No. Please add the three contributors and their specific roles.

Contributors identifies the people who performed the work described in the update.

4. revised

Sponsor: Send me the wording and I'll use the revised version.

Revised describes a corrected version incorporating the missing names and roles.

11 Conversation answers

Reversing a decision without undermining the team

E Extended conversation

Pages 82-83

1. hold off. Turn 2. Hold off means postpone an action temporarily while a relevant concern is resolved.

2. narrow down. Turn 8. Narrow down means reduce the possible causes or options through further investigation.

3. decision point. Turn 12. Decision point identifies the choice that must be made now, rather than every later question.

4. invalidate. Turn 15. Invalidate means make something no longer valid; the failed test does not cancel all completed work.

5. release criteria. Turn 18. Release criteria are the conditions that must be met before the launch can proceed.

6. make the call. Turn 20. Make the call means make the decision after reviewing the relevant information.

F Transfer exchange

Page 84

1. plan

Supervisor: Should I cancel the whole launch plan?

Plan refers to all coordinated launch work, which has not been abandoned.

2. paused

Omar: No. The release is paused while the archive issue is investigated.

Paused describes a temporary stop rather than cancellation of the entire project.

3. dependencies

Supervisor: I'll retain the completed work and flag any dependencies on the fix.

Dependencies identifies tasks whose completion or accuracy relies on the forthcoming repair.

4. checkpoint

Omar: Exactly. We'll review the remaining criteria at tomorrow's checkpoint.

Checkpoint is the scheduled review where the team will assess readiness again.

11

Find the move you need

Use these as precise language models. Replace details only when you know the actual facts, authority, and agreed conditions.

01 Check meaning before assuming agreement

Specify the reference: When you say "fine," are you referring to the date or the overall approach?

Check a commitment: Can I record that as a commitment, or is it still a possibility?

Close the loop: I will send the revised record and ask you to confirm it.

Full phrase set: pages 7-8 | Dialogue: pages 10-11

02 Challenge ideas respectfully

Ask for the premise: Which assumption are you challenging?

Name the distinction: Let us separate the objective from the proposed method.

Close firmly: We will revise the account count and test the workload before expanding.

Full phrase set: pages 16-17 | Dialogue: pages 19-20

03 Make authority and participation clear

Invite a recommendation: Bring me your preferred option and the reason for it.

Set a limit: That discretion does not include additional spending.

Schedule review: We will review the trial after two weeks using the agreed criteria.

Full phrase set: pages 25-26 | Dialogue: pages 28-29

04 Negotiate realistic commitments

Identify the purpose: What decision does the Friday meeting need to make?

State a firm limit: I cannot commit to verified figures before the reconciliation is complete.

Confirm the choice: Then our agreement is Friday estimates, followed by Monday verification.

Full phrase set: pages 34-35 | Dialogue: pages 37-38

Keep the conversation productive

Use these as precise language models. Replace details only when you know the actual facts, authority, and agreed conditions.

05 Include every voice in a meeting

Stop overlap: One voice at a time, please; the remote line cannot distinguish us.

Invite a specific view: Arun, what remains unverified in the routing check?

Close with ownership: The next action belongs to Arun; the go-live decision remains with me.

Full phrase set: pages 43-44 | Dialogue: pages 46-47

06 Give specific, useful feedback

Name the occasion: For each of the last two weekly reports, we agreed on Thursday noon.

Ask without assigning motive: What prevented the Thursday delivery?

Define follow-up: We will review the next two reports at a short Friday check-in.

Full phrase set: pages 52-53 | Dialogue: pages 55-56

07 Coordinate across offices

Ask about use: Which decision does each daily figure support?

Offer a reporting design: Could we use the dashboard for routine figures and a separate alert for exceptions?

Test the arrangement: Let us trial the format for two weeks and review missed alerts and preparation time.

Full phrase set: pages 61-62 | Dialogue: pages 64-65

08 Repair misunderstandings and build trust

Own the action: I interrupted you twice and summarized your concern inaccurately.

Explain without excusing: I was trying to manage time; that does not justify misrepresenting your point.

Check the repair: After the next meeting, we will check whether the new turn-taking rule was followed.

Full phrase set: pages 70-71 | Dialogue: pages 73-74

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

acceptance criteria	agree acceptance criteria	33
accountability	retain accountability	23
accountable owner	name an accountable owner	24
acknowledge	acknowledge the impact	68
acknowledgment	acknowledge receipt	5
acknowledgment time	set an acknowledgment time	60
action item	assign an action item	41
action plan	agree a focused action plan	51
ad hominem	avoid ad hominem attacks	15
agenda item	close an agenda item	42
airtime	share airtime fairly	42
alignment	check alignment on the date	6
approval boundary	respect the approval boundary	24
approval matrix	check the approval matrix	24
assumption	test an assumption	6
asynchronous input	collect asynchronous input	41
attribution	check an attribution	50
attribution of credit	ensure accurate attribution of credit	69
audit trail	preserve an audit trail	59
authorization	obtain authorization	5
autonomy	grant operational autonomy	24
baseline	establish a schedule baseline	33
best effort	make a best-effort attempt	32
bottleneck	remove a bottleneck	50

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

buffer build in a time buffer	33
burden of proof meet the burden of proof	14
capacity constraint work within a capacity constraint	14
caveat include a caveat	32
check-in schedule a check-in	50
clarification seek clarification	6
coaching hold a coaching conversation	51
commitment make a limited commitment	68
common ground establish common ground	15
concession make a limited concession	14
conditional agreement record conditional agreement	5
confidence level state the confidence level	33
consensus build consensus	23
constructive dissent invite constructive dissent	15
consultation hold a consultation	23
contingency plan a contingency	32
contributing factor identify contributing factors	51
correction circulate a correction	68
corrective action agree corrective action	50
corroboration seek corroboration of the account	69
counterproposal put forward a counterproposal	14
critical path identify the critical path	33
cross-check cross-check the meeting summary	42
cross-functional dependency manage a cross-functional dependency	60

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

crosstalk reduce crosstalk	41
data completeness check data completeness	60
data lineage trace the data lineage	60
data owner identify the data owner	60
de-escalation support de-escalation	69
decision gate pass a decision gate	24
decision log update the decision log	41
decision owner name the decision owner	23
decision rights clarify decision rights	23
defensiveness reduce defensiveness	68
deferred item assign an owner to a deferred item	42
delegation delegate a decision	23
deliverable define the deliverable	32
dependency resolve a dependency	5
dependency risk flag a dependency risk	33
devil's advocate play devil's advocate	14
directional evidence treat the result as directional evidence	15
discrepancy resolve a discrepancy	6
discretion exercise discretion	23
dissent record dissent	41
duplicate entry eliminate duplicate entry	59
early-warning signal act on an early-warning signal	51
endorsement endorse a proposal	5
escalation path follow the escalation path	59

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

escalation threshold	agree an escalation threshold	23
estimate	provide an estimate	32
evidence base	strengthen the evidence base	14
evidence-based feedback	give evidence-based feedback	51
exception	approve an exception	23
exception reporting	use exception reporting	59
explicit	obtain explicit approval	6
extrapolate	extrapolate from a small trial	15
face-saving	offer a face-saving correction	69
facilitation	provide neutral facilitation	42
false dichotomy	challenge a false dichotomy	15
feasibility	assess feasibility	14
follow-through	demonstrate follow-through	50
follow-up	set a follow-up	68
go/no-go decision	make a go/no-go decision	5
good faith	act in good faith	68
green light	give the green light	5
guardrail	set clear guardrails	23
handoff	clarify the handoff	59
hard deadline	meet a hard deadline	32
impact	explain the impact	50
impact	separate intent from impact	68
implicit	avoid relying on implicit consent	6
in principle	agree in principle	6

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

information requirement	clarify the information requirement	60
informed stakeholder	keep an informed stakeholder updated	24
intent	explain an intent	68
intent-impact gap	address the intent-impact gap	69
lead time	allow sufficient lead time	50
local context	explain the local context	59
local discretion	define local discretion	60
mandate	define the team's mandate	24
measurable standard	set a measurable standard	51
meeting owner	confirm the meeting owner	42
minimum viable scope	agree the minimum viable scope	33
mischaracterize	mischaracterize a concern	68
non-defensive response	give a non-defensive response	69
non-negotiable	state a non-negotiable	14
observable behavior	describe observable behavior	50
omission	correct an omission	69
operating model	align the operating model	60
overcommit	avoid overcommitting	32
oversight	retain management oversight	24
ownership	take ownership of the mistake	69
paraphrase	paraphrase a concern	41
parking lot	put an item in the parking lot	41
pattern	identify a pattern	50
pending	approval pending review	6

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

performance expectation clarify a performance expectation	50
performance gap identify a performance gap	51
personal remark avoid personal remarks	14
point of contention isolate the point of contention	15
pre-read circulate the pre-read	42
premise challenge the premise	14
prerequisite satisfy a prerequisite	6
procedural fairness protect procedural fairness	69
provisional provisional launch date	5
pushback offer constructive pushback	14
qualification add a qualification	6
quorum confirm a quorum	41
RACI use a RACI matrix	23
range estimate provide a range estimate	33
rationale explain the rationale	15
read-back give a read-back	5
rebaseline rebaseline the delivery schedule	33
rebuttal offer an evidence-based rebuttal	15
recap give a brief recap	42
reciprocity build reciprocity over time	69
reconciliation complete the reconciliation	32
recurrence prevent recurrence	51
red line state a clear red line	15
refresh cycle confirm the refresh cycle	60

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

remedy agree a proportionate remedy	69
remit stay within your remit	23
repair make a concrete repair	68
reporting burden reduce the reporting burden	59
reporting cadence agree a reporting cadence	59
reporting line clarify the reporting line	60
reporting period specify the reporting period	60
reputational harm address reputational harm	69
reservation express a reservation	5
resource allocation confirm resource allocation	33
retained authority specify retained authority	24
retraction issue a retraction	68
revocable grant revocable authority	24
rework reduce avoidable rework	51
rolling forecast maintain a rolling forecast	33
root cause investigate the root cause	51
round-robin use a round-robin	41
SBI use an SBI structure [2]	50
scope clarify the scope	5
scope creep prevent scope creep	32
separation of duties maintain separation of duties	24
service level monitor the service level	59
side conversation pause a side conversation	42
sign-off get final sign-off	5

Find a term and its context

The page number leads to the definition and a typical word combination. Repeated terms have separate entries when they serve different lesson contexts.

single source of truth maintain a single source of truth	59
slippage report schedule slippage	33
span of control review a manager's span of control	24
speaking queue manage the speaking queue	42
stress-test stress-test an assumption	14
substantiation request substantiation	15
supersede supersede the earlier minutes	6
support request make a concrete support request	51
synthesis offer a concise synthesis	42
tentative set a tentative date	6
the floor give someone the floor	41
threshold set an alert threshold	59
timebox timebox the discussion	41
timeliness improve report timeliness	51
trade-off make a trade-off	32
turn-taking manage turn-taking	41
turnaround time agree a turnaround time	32
unresolved question return to an unresolved question	42
upstream input obtain upstream input	50
verified verified figures	32
version control maintain version control	60
viable alternative offer a viable alternative	15
visibility maintain visibility	59
working agreement establish a working agreement	68

Original cases. Clear boundaries.

The scenarios, dialogues, vocabulary explanations, tasks, and answer rationales are original English Ladder teaching material. They are not transcripts of real employees or research interviews. They illustrate language choices, not a universal American communication style.

[1] Council of Europe. Common European Framework of Reference for Languages: mediation resources.

[Open the original source](#)

Used for the broad learning aims of collaborative interaction, clarification, turn-taking, and helping people establish shared meaning. The B2-C1 study range is an editorial choice, not an official endorsement or assessment.

[2] Center for Creative Leadership. Use Situation-Behavior-Impact (SBI) to Understand Intent (2025).

[Open the original source](#)

Informs the distinction between observed behavior, impact, and assumed intent in Lesson 6. SBI is attributed to its originator; the cases and dialogue wording here are original.

[3] Amy Edmondson. Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams (1999). Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350-383.

[Open the original source](#)

Provides background on interpersonal risk and team learning. The study does not establish national personality types, and this book does not treat its results as rules about individuals.

Phil Stilwell

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